OCTOBER 2026 | VOLUME 7 ISSUE 12

FLORIDA FOOTBALL. ALWAYS.

GATORBAIT MAGAZINE

NO. 17 FLORIDA VS. NO. 3 GEORGIA

Game Day edition. Saturday, Oct. 31, 3:30 p.m. ET, ABC. Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta.

BUDDY MARTIN
Sumrall Knows the Math

FRANZ BEARD
Thoughts of the Day

BRENDEN MARTIN
Snubbed in Atlanta

THE SHOW
Buddy, live for Georgia week

AP POLL
Florida Is No. 17

HALLOWEEN IN ATLANTA

GEORGIA WEEK

Sumrall's first Florida-Georgia, in a new city: Year 11 against Year One

Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media (file, Sept. 26, 2026)

FLORIDA GATORS. MORE THAN A GAME.

GATORBAIT MAGAZINE · GAME DAY EDITION

Florida vs. Georgia · Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026

Made for your phone. Scroll down to read.

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THE GAME

No. 17 FLORIDA 5-2 · 3-2 SEC	VS	No. 3 GEORGIA 6-1 · 4-1 SEC

Saturday, Oct. 31 · 3:30 p.m. ET · ABC

Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta. Neutral site

Indoors. Artificial turf, per ESPN's venue listing. The game leaves Jacksonville for Atlanta this year and Tampa next while EverBank Stadium is renovated.

LINE	TOTAL
Georgia -11.5	55.5
SERIES	**ESPN MATCHUP PREDICTOR**
UF trails 44-57-2	Florida 17.9%, Georgia 82.1%

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 27. Kickoff, TV and neutral site also on FloridaGators.com broadcast information, Oct. 27. Series count: FloridaGators.com opponent history.

FOUR KEYS

1. BAUGH AGAINST THE BEST RUN DEFENSE HE HAS SEEN

Jadan Baugh has 763 yards and 13 touchdowns on 135 carries, and Florida runs for 194.3 a game. Georgia allows 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry, both the lowest figures on this page.

2. THIRD DOWN, BOTH WAYS

Georgia converts 54.0% of its third downs and holds opponents to 35.9%. Florida converts 44.6% and allows 43.7%. The Gators' defense has 22 sacks to Georgia's 22, and Georgia has allowed only 8.

3. STOCKTON AGAINST A PASS DEFENSE THAT ALLOWS 255 A GAME

Gunner Stockton is 117 of 158 for 1,570 yards, 16 touchdowns and four interceptions; Georgia completes 71.6% at 9.7 yards an attempt. Florida allows 255.0 passing yards a game.

4. THE QUARTERBACK SUMRALL WILL NOT NAME

Aaron Philo is 105 of 149 for 1,341 yards, nine touchdowns and three interceptions this season; Tramell Jones Jr. made his first start in the 27-24 win at Texas. Sumrall said Monday he is not telling Georgia who starts. Dallas Wilson leads the receivers with 29 catches for 403 yards.

ESPN 2026 team statistics and game-summary leaders, Oct. 27 (both teams seven games). The quarterback line: Jon Sumrall's Monday press conference, as reported in Buddy Martin's column.

TALE OF THE TAPE

Season, per game: both teams through seven games

	FLORIDA	GEORGIA
POINTS SCORED	39.6	43
TOTAL YARDS	450.9	469.9
RUSHING YARDS	194.3	197.7
YARDS A CARRY	4.8	6
PASSING YARDS	256.6	272.1
POINTS ALLOWED	28.3	15.9
RUSH YARDS ALLOWED	121.6	90.3
PASS YARDS ALLOWED	255	185
THIRD DOWN %	44.6	54
OPP. THIRD DOWN %	43.7	35.9

SACKS

FLORIDA	GEORGIA
22	22

POSSESSION (MINUTES)

FLORIDA	GEORGIA
33	30.2

ESPN 2026 team statistics, Oct. 27. Points scored and allowed are figured from ESPN's final scores; possession minutes from ESPN's season possession seconds divided by games played.

THE SERIES: FIVE STRAIGHT FOR GEORGIA

FloridaGators.com counts the series at Georgia 57, Florida 44, two ties, starting in 1915. The Bulldogs have won the last five, all in Jacksonville, by a combined 177-87: 34-7 in 2021, 42-20 in 2022, 43-20 in 2023, 34-20 in 2024 and 24-20 last Nov. 1. Florida's last win was 44-28 in 2020; the Gators are 2-8 in the last 10.

Year	Florida	Site
2021	L 7-34	Neutral
2022	L 20-42	Neutral
2023	L 20-43	Neutral
2024	L 20-34	Neutral
2025	L 20-24	Neutral

FloridaGators.com, football opponent history vs. Georgia (44-57-2, streak L5, last 10: 2-8; the 2025 final confirmed on ESPN, event 401752755). Georgia's own count includes a disputed 1904 game and reads 58-44-2.

AVAILABILITY

ESPN lists no injuries for either team as of Tuesday, Oct. 27. The official SEC availability report posts later in the week on FloridaGators.com.

Source: ESPN game summary (event 401856734) and team rosters, Oct. 27; official SEC availability report posts before kickoff

COVER STORY · BUDDY MARTIN

SUMRALL KNOWS THE MATH

Year 11 against Year One. Buddy Martin on why Jon Sumrall is not telling Georgia who takes the snap, and on what the Bulldogs have that Florida still has to grow.

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026

> **‘You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it.’**
>
> BUDDY MARTIN

Orange and blue on one side, red and black on the other: Florida and Georgia fans split the stands in Jacksonville in 2008. This year the game moves to Atlanta, where the split may look more like 60-40, Bulldogs.
Photo by jasonduhon, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons. Original photograph, unaltered.

You can’t buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it.

Georgia week usually brings out the worst in a football coach. He puffs his chest, praises the opponent’s long snapper and swears it’s just another game, which is like saying Halloween is just another Saturday. This one happens to fall on Halloween, which seems about right.

Jon Sumrall skipped the theater Monday. He walked into the room and handed over something Gator fans may not want to hear: a scouting report on why the Bulldogs are who they are, and why Florida isn't. Not yet, anyway.

"I think it's year 11 for Kirby there," Sumrall said. "You can tell they have layered development."

Layered. Like a wedding cake, or a lasagna, or the debt Florida has piled up in this series. Georgia recruited great players "year-in, year-out." They developed them. They're "calloused," "strong" and "physical," and all of it, Sumrall said, has "been built over time."

Translation: You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it, and Georgia has been out there fertilizing since the Obama administration.

GEORGIA, GEORGIA, GEORGIA

"Georgia, Georgia, Georgia, Georgia," Sumrall said.

No, this was not Sumrall trying to invoke that Ray Charles classic as a singer. It was just a dose of pure reality.

He did his bye-week homework on Georgia's personnel report, the sheet that lists each player's previous school. Down the Bulldogs'

list, over and over, the previous school was the same school. Kirby isn't running a football program so much as a family farm.

"When we can become that," Sumrall said, "is when you… create consistency."

Now flip to Florida's sheet. Roughly half the Gators were here last year. The other half just showed up from a high school or somewhere else, a few of them probably still asking where the cafeteria is.

"They're in Year 11," Sumrall said. "We're in Year One."

That's not an excuse. It's arithmetic.

Every Gator fan who has watched Georgia treat this game like a standing dinner reservation needs to learn the math.

NEVER AGAIN 3

Sumrall didn't sugarcoat his first winter. Florida hit the transfer portal "just to be able to field a football team that could practice."

Not to win a championship. To practice. That's like shopping for a car so you'll have something to park in the driveway.

December and January were a minefield. Players he thought were staying left, and players he figured were gone stayed.

“You didn’t know where you were going to step and what was going to blow up on you,” he said.

Welcome to modern college football, where the roster has a revolving door and every agent has a cell phone.

His plan from here sounds almost quaint: Recruit high school kids. Develop them. Keep them. Use the portal for six to 10 difference-makers a year to plug real holes, not to restock the whole pantry.

“It better never again be high 20s, 30s,” he said, “or we got a real problem.”

He also noted that Georgia doesn’t shop the portal for backups.

When the Dawgs have a need, they go get a great player like Isiah Canion.

“They don’t go out and just go to the portal to get a third-string guy,” Sumrall said.

Some programs shop at Neiman Marcus. Others hit the clearance rack hoping for a 46 long.

Then came the line of the day, on Georgia linebacker Chris Cole, whom Kirby has been raving about: “If I had Chris Cole on my roster, I’d be raving about retaining him too.”

THE ONE-YEAR FLIP

Nobody in Gainesville gets misty-eyed over “process.” Gator fans want to hear about process the way they want to hear about root canals. Sumrall knows it, so he tried to have it both ways.

“They didn’t just do a one-year flip,” he said of Georgia. “They’ve done a build from the ground up. And I want a one-year flip, too. I want to win every day.”

Don’t we all, coach. Don’t we all.

He admitted his short-term plan has been hit-and-miss: “some of it’s gone well, some of it hasn’t.” The record agrees.

An upset of then-No. 4 Ole Miss. Back-to-back losses to Missouri and South Carolina. Then a 27-24 win at Texas that lifted the Gators to No. 17.

One week they look like world-beaters, the next week they’re beating themselves. That’s a year-one team.

THE QUARTERBACK SHELL GAME

Then came the question everybody really came for: Aaron Philo or Tramell Jones Jr.?

Sumrall answered it the way a politician answers a question about taxes.

“Both guys are available. Believe in both guys,” he said. “Not going to name a starter today… We need both those guys to be ready to play.”

He’ll decide “middleish of the week,” probably Wednesday. And don’t wait by the fax machine.

“There’s not going to be a big QB1 announcement for this game or any game,” he said.

Why all the secrecy? Start with health. Philo, the Georgia Tech transfer who started the first six games, is coming back from the shoulder injury that sidelined him at Texas. Jones, who won his first career start in Austin, came out of it with “wear-and-tear” injuries. Both practiced Monday, and Sumrall says how they hold up “matters.”

But let’s not be naive. Making Georgia prepare for two quarterbacks costs Florida nothing but a little sleep.

Philo is the polished passer: 70.5 percent completions, nine touchdowns, three picks. Jones is the sophomore who hit a fourth-and-12 throw and ran for the game-sealing first down at Texas.

Kirby is already treating it as a two-man problem.

“One beat Ole Miss handedly and one beat Texas on the road,” Smart said, adding that Buster Faulkner “can play to the strengths of each guy.”

That’s exactly what Sumrall wants. Let Georgia’s defensive staff stay up late watching two guys.

And there’s a little extra seasoning: Philo, the former Prince Avenue Christian star, holds Georgia’s high school passing record. Imagine the home-state kid beating the Dawgs in their own capital city.

TV TV TV TV TV

Watch: Sumrall on Florida’s quarterback decision — Monday’s press conference, via Gator Bait Media.

GET YOUR FILTHY HANDS OFF IT

And now a word from our sponsor. Or rather, a word against them.

This year's game has an official name, Gawd help us: the Invesco QQQ Atlanta Gridiron Classic.

That's how it reads on the stadium's event page and the ticket listings. It sounds like an index fund that sponsors a charity 10K.

Somewhere a marketing VP got a bonus for that, and somewhere Bill Kastelz, the Times-Union sports editor who coined the Cocktail Party name, is spinning like a rotisserie chicken.

We know what this game is. It's Florida-Georgia. Or Georgia-Florida, depending on the year and your bloodline. It was the World's Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party until the college presidents got squeamish, and every fan with a cooler kept calling it that anyway. It has belonged to Jacksonville nearly every year since 1933, and it'll go back there in 2028.

Corporate America's attempt to gussy it up may muddy the fender a little. It won't wreck the car. Florida-Georgia is stronger than all this corporate filth that passes for branding, or rebranding.

So please, please, please. Get your filthy hands off of it.

THE VERDICT

Sumrall doesn't sound like a coach making excuses. He sounds like one who has studied the opponent closely and is honest about how far Florida has to go. In this business, honesty is rarer than a Georgia fan who doesn't bring up the scoreboard.

Georgia is coming off a home loss to Auburn, which should make the Dawgs about as cheerful as a wet cat.

The tickets are split down the middle on paper, but in Atlanta the crowd may turn out more like 60-40, Bulldogs. Call it a semi-home game with a neutral-site invoice.

The Bulldogs are still the Bulldogs, built layer by layer over a decade. Sumrall has one year of layers.

On Saturday, we find out if that's enough, or if Florida's going to get the Ray Charles treatment again: Georgia on its mind, all the way home.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

THE LEAD · FRANZ BEARD

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: OCTOBER 27, 2026

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 27, 2026



Jon Sumrall before the Ole Miss game, Sept. 26. File photo. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

"I think anybody that says it's just another game doesn't have a real good pulse of what reality is in college football or to our fan base."

Jon Sumrall said that Monday at his press conference at the Heavener Football Center in Gainesville, a combination of excitement and reverence showing on his face and in his demeanor. Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta (3:30 p.m., ABC) will be his first Florida-Georgia game. The fact that the game will be played somewhere other than

Jacksonville, the long-standing traditional home of the rivalry game does nothing to dampen his enthusiasm or his understanding of what winning this game means.

It is more, much more, than border state bragging rights and the importance goes far beyond two ranked teams squaring off, both of them very much in the hunt for a second trip to Atlanta this season for the SEC Championship Game and beyond that, the College Football Playoff. For the 17th-ranked Gators (5-2, 3-2 SEC), a loss would jeopardize their chances of making the SEC Championship Game for the first time since 2020 and reaching the College Football Playoff for the first time. The four-team playoff introduced in 2014 expanded to 12 teams in 2024. For No. 3 Georgia (6-1, 4-1 SEC), it is a matter of keeping up with the SEC Joneses, in this case the rather surprising Kentucky Wildcats (7-1, 5-1 SEC). Since 2011 Georgia has played for the SEC championship 10 times, winning four, all of them since Kirby Smart became the head coach. The Bulldogs broke a 41-year national championship drought in 2021 and repeated in 2022.

HOW THE RIVALRY CHANGED

There was a time when the roles were reversed and Florida was the dominant team. Steve Spurrier went 11-1 against Georgia, won six SEC championships and the 1996 national title. Ron Zook won two out of three and might have had a perfect record against the Bulldogs except he was fired on the Monday before the 2004 Florida-Georgia game. Urban Meyer was 5-1 against Georgia, winning both SEC and national championships in 2006 and 2008.

Since Florida's 21-year dominance that began in Spurrier's first year on the job in 1990, the Gators have been a revolving door of coaches. Sumrall, in his first year on the job, is the fifth head coach since Meyer took a hiatus after the 2010 season. Georgia, meanwhile, has been the picture of stability. Mark Richt took over the Georgia program from Jim Donnan in 2001, and won two SEC championships in 15 years, going 5-10 against the Gators. Richt was fired and Georgia native son Kirby Smart took over the program in 2016. Since then Georgia is 123-22. In his 11th season on the job, Smart is 8-2 against the Gators, losing only the 2016 and 2020 games.

What Georgia has going for it is momentum, which only adds to the history and significance of Florida-Georgia. For Florida fans who remember the good old days from 1990-2010, what Georgia has done under Kirby Smart is a painful reminder of what happens when there is a confluence of good coaching, exceptional recruiting and stability at the top.

Georgia has it. It is Sumrall's job to restore some sanity (that's from the Florida perspective) to the rivalry. More than half the players who will suit up for Florida Saturday have never played in this game. They came to Florida from the transfer portal or as wide-eyed freshmen. Georgia's program under Smart has grown to a point of using the portal only to add a few impact players each year. Nearly the entire roster is home grown.

"Georgia the way they've done it and the way they've got it built now, they don't go out and just go to the portal to get a third-string guy," Sumrall said, adding "Most of their roster is because they've done a good job of layering. Our roster, there's a lot of guys playing Saturday, I'm teaching them what this game needs to mean to us. And we haven't had a recent history of the success we need to have in this rivalry to make it as competitive as it should be."

To put that in perspective, Georgia has won five consecutive games against Florida. The Gators last beat the Bulldogs in 2020.

Sumrall spent the bye week balancing the history and traditions that have always made this one of the great rivalry games in the country with what has to happen for the Gators to get their third win over a top-ten ranked team this season. Georgia enters as the higher-ranked team.

“First, you want to make sure they understand it is a rivalry game,” Sumrall said. “They need to have awareness of that. And then you have to bring it back to, while there’s all this heightened publicity around the game, it’s still a football game and what wins football games. So you have to lean on both. You can’t just be all hype about highlight videos and the history of the game, without, hey, here are the plays we’re gonna run, here’s how we’re gonna block them, here’s the progression of the quarterback, here’s where we’re trying to tackle him, here’s what we’re trying to do on defense to slow them down. That’s the stuff that really matters. But I do think the guys need to understand that the game has, it counts for one game on your record, but it has a different feel.”

A different feel, yes, when the Florida discussion has everything to do with traditions and the recent history of the game that highly favors Georgia. Smart, who was on the losing side in Athens the last time Florida-Georgia had to take a vacation from Jacksonville due to stadium issues, can speak to his team from a personal perspective. He was on the field when Eric Kresser threw a touchdown pass to Travis McGriff to finish off the Gators' 52-17 win over Georgia in 1995, the first time an opposing team had ever hung 50 or more on the Bulldogs at Sanford Stadium. He was also on the only Georgia team that beat Spurrier in 1997.

BUILDING A ROSTER FOR THE RIVALRY

And now, Smart is the driving force for an era of Georgia dominance. For Sumrall to change the momentum of the rivalry, he has to build a roster that is Georgia-like in that it is mostly home grown and stacked with talent so that when one player goes down due to injury a player of equal or greater talent is next man up. When a Georgia player leaves for the NFL as so many do, Smart cherry picks from the portal.

"I actually studied their roster some during the bye week because I do think they've been really consistent," Sumrall said. "And when you look through our personnel reports that we do on

each team as we get ready to go into a game week, it tells us previous school – whether you know high school, college slash high school. These guys have a lot of guys' previous school from a college standpoint, it was Georgia. So I think as you get to the model, like year one of our program, a lot of our guys on their previous school it says somewhere other than Florida.

"We retained a good number of players: roughly half our roster were here last year, but the other half was not. So half of our roster says the high school they just came from, or a different school and so I think as you build, and like I said earlier, they're in year 11, we're in year one. As you build in year four, five, six, seven, whatever, you start to move forward. In a perfect world in the portal year and year out, you're adding six to 10 difference makers. In some years, it might be five or might be 12, so I'm not locking myself into like, hey, we're only adding six to 10 every year. Some years it might be five. Some years it might have to be 12 or 13. It better never again be high 20s, 30s, or we got a real problem. So as you build your roster, you want to add portal pieces that are like frontline starters when you have immediate glaring needs and holes. This past year, we had to go

out and get guys out of the portal just to be able to field a football team that could practice. Never again will that be the case here, I hope."

It shouldn't be lost on anyone that Florida comes into this game with the momentum of a 27-24 win over Texas, which just two weeks before had been ranked No. 1. Georgia spent a week at the top following the Texas loss to Oklahoma that knocked the Longhorns out of the top spot, but in their first game after ascending to No. 1, the Bulldogs were stunned by unranked Auburn, 27-24. Yes, the same team that Florida beat 44-39 in Auburn whacked Georgia in Athens.

With a win, Florida keeps hope alive. With a loss, Georgia is still very much in the hunt for the SEC Championship Game and the playoff.

So, much is at stake Saturday, which is the way it should be. Great rivalry games deserve far reaching consequences and Florida-Georgia has them. By no means is this just another game.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

THE BIG PICTURE · BRENDEN MARTIN ON GAMEDAY AND KIRBY

SNUBBED IN ATLANTA: GAMEDAY PASSED, KIRBY SHRUGGED, FLORIDA NOTICED

College GameDay went to Bloomington, Kirby Smart called Florida's quarterbacks "completely capable," and the rivalry moved 70 miles from his campus. Brenden Martin reads the transcripts.

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026



Florida and Georgia in Jacksonville, Nov. 2, 2024. File photo. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

I am not a detective. I read college football press conference transcripts for a living, which is a worse job and, this week, nearly the same

one.

Because something about this Florida-Georgia week does not add up, and it is not the point spread.

Begin with the smallest mystery. ESPN's College GameDay is a show that travels the country looking for the biggest game in America, and this week it found one in Bloomington, Indiana, where the Hoosiers will host Minnesota. Minnesota is 5-2. The Gophers are a perfectly respectable football team, the kind you are happy to see on your schedule in November, preferably at noon, preferably already over. Indiana is the defending national champion and ranked No. 4, so the show is not crazy. It is just not at our game, and our game is Florida and Georgia, in Atlanta, for the first time in the modern history of the rivalry.

Georgia, for the record, has already been on the show this year. GameDay went to Tuscaloosa for Georgia and Alabama in Week 6. The Bulldogs have had their close-up. It was the rivalry itself, a hundred years old and temporarily homeless, that got left at the curb in a nice suit. The SEC's own pregame show will be in Atlanta on Saturday morning, Tim Tebow and all. The big one will be at a fountain in Bloomington.

KIRBY'S QUARTERBACK ASSESSMENT

Which brings us to the main witness. Kirby Smart met the media on Monday, and I have now read his remarks three times. This tells you nothing good about my social life and a great deal about his adjectives.

Kirby was warm about nearly everyone. Jon Sumrall has brought energy and physicality to Florida. The coordinators have his respect. Buster Faulkner, once an assistant on Kirby's own staff, was introduced like family at a reunion: one of the best offensive minds in the country, a close friend, respect upon respect. If compliments were currency, Buster could retire.

Then Kirby arrived at Florida's quarterbacks. He called Aaron Philo and Tramell Jones Jr. "very talented" and "good players," credited their wins and said Faulkner can play to their strengths. Fair enough. But a man has to know what he heard, and what I heard was "completely capable," followed by "plenty capable." The way you describe a rental car. It has four wheels. It runs. It is completely capable of reaching the airport.

Oh, and just one more thing. In Buster's offense, Kirby explained, "it doesn't require the quarterback to be perfect."

There it is. Everything else in that press conference was a man being gracious. To my ear, that sentence sounded more revealing than the compliments. He respects the machine. The two young men operating it, the ones who beat Ole Miss and Texas, are simply the help. Kirby even recited their accomplishments himself, both wins, out loud, and then handed them the same word you would use for a hotel shower with decent water pressure.

I do not blame him for saying it. I would just like it printed somewhere large, preferably where a Florida locker room can see it all week.

Kirby had one more opinion worth writing down, this one about the game leaving Jacksonville this year and landing in Atlanta, about 70 miles from his campus. He does not think the venue matters much to the teams, he said. For the fans, the game in the 'Benz will probably be a unique experience.

Isn't that generous. A unique experience. The neutral site in this rivalry just moved into Georgia's state capital, into a dome my dad figures will split something like 60-40 for the Bulldogs, and the head coach of the Bulldogs has studied the situation and concluded that geography is a non-issue. I believe he believes

that. If my commute to the biggest game of my season were that short, I would find geography pretty uninteresting myself.

Jacksonville, for all its humidity and questionable stadium food, had one virtue that can never be replaced. Georgia did not own it. Nobody owned it. That was the entire arrangement, and it survived for the better part of a century because both sides understood the value of a room neither family controlled. This year the room has an Atlanta address and a corporate name, and half the sport has decided not to notice.

Look at the evidence. The national stage went to Indiana. The opposing coach praised our play-caller like a brother and our quarterbacks like appliances. The neutral site leans red, the polls have Florida at No. 17 in one and No. 20 in the other.

THE PATTERN AFTER A BYE WEEK

One final detail, and then I will let everyone go. Kirby Smart has lost back-to-back regular-season games exactly twice in 11 seasons at Georgia, both times in his first season, 2016. The last time it happened, the order went like this: a loss, a bye week, and then a 24-10 loss to Florida.

Georgia's last game was a 27-24 loss at home to Auburn. Auburn's quarterback ran for 115 yards on that defense, and Florida, earlier this season, scored 44 on Auburn. Georgia has since had its bye week. I am not saying history repeats itself. Detectives deal in facts, and the fact is simply that the pattern is sitting there on the table where anybody can look at it.

Florida has Vernell Brown III back at practice, with Sumrall optimistic about his possible return, Jadan Baugh to lean on and a defense that already won once this month in a stadium where it was not wanted. Sumrall still will not name his quarterback, which means Georgia's staff gets to spend the week preparing for two capable young men and one uncomfortable sentence from their own head coach.

We are one sovereign Gator Nation. See you in Atlanta, where the venue does not matter, the quarterbacks are capable and absolutely nothing suspicious is going on.

Florida and Georgia kick off at 3:30 p.m. EDT Saturday on ABC at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

BY THE NUMBERS

Six figures that frame Saturday

-11.5

GEORGIA, THE LINE

Total 55.5. DraftKings line via ESPN pickcenter, Oct. 27.

82.1%

ESPN PREDICTOR, GEORGIA

Florida at 17.9% in the ESPN matchup predictor.

L5

FLORIDA IN THE SERIES

Five straight Georgia wins. Florida's last was 44-28 in 2020. FloridaGators.com has the series at 44-57-2.

763

BAUGH RUSHING YARDS

Jadan Baugh: 135 carries, 13 touchdowns. Georgia allows 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry.

54.0%

GEORGIA ON THIRD DOWN

Florida's defense allows 43.7% on third down; the Florida offense converts 44.6%.

15.9

GEORGIA POINTS ALLOWED

A game, figured from ESPN's seven final scores. Florida scores 39.6 and allows 28.3.

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (event 401856734), ESPN 2026 team statistics and schedules, Oct. 27; FloridaGators.com series history.

WHAT WE'RE WATCHING

GatorBait Media writers, in their own words

> **You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it, and Georgia has been out there fertilizing since the Obama administration.**
>
> BUDDY MARTIN

> **Georgia has it. It is Sumrall's job to restore some sanity (that's from the Florida perspective) to the rivalry. More than half the players who will suit up for Florida Saturday have never played in this game.**
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> **BRENDEN MARTIN**

Lines from the writers' published columns on gatorbaitmedia.com, Oct. 26-27.

THE DESK · SATURDAY MATH

TWO SETS OF NUMBERS, ONE POINT SPREAD

The market says Georgia by 11.5. The season averages say something closer to a touchdown. Both can be true, and the gap between them is Saturday's story.

BY THE GATORBAIT MEDIA DESK

> **The averages say a touchdown. The line says more.**

POINTS A GAME, SEASON AVERAGES (SEVEN GAMES EACH)



Georgia is favored by 11.5 at 3:30 p.m. ET on Saturday, and the total is 55.5. Do the arithmetic and the market is picturing something near Georgia 33.5, Florida 22.

Now put the season averages side by side. Florida scores 39.6 points a game. Georgia allows 15.9. Georgia scores 43.0. Florida allows 28.3. Split each matchup down the middle and you land at about 28 for Florida and 36 for Georgia. That is a touchdown and change, not 11.5. It is not a prediction. It is a reminder that

the line and the stats are answering different questions. The line knows about a neutral site in Georgia's state capital, a five-game losing streak in the series and a Florida quarterback who has not been named. The averages do not.

Where the line has a case: Georgia's defense has given up 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry, and Florida's offense is built on Jadan Baugh's 763 yards. Georgia converts 54.0 percent of its third downs; Florida's defense allows 43.7. Georgia has allowed eight sacks all season. Florida has taken nine.

Where the averages have a case: Florida's 39.6 points a game include 44 at Auburn and 52 against Ole Miss, but the Gators have scored 27 or fewer in each of the last three games: 17 at Missouri, 19 against South Carolina, 27 at Texas. Georgia's lone loss came at home to Auburn, 27-24, the same Saturday Florida won in Austin.

The desk's view: the spread is about the quarterback question and the streak, not the stat sheet. If Florida's run game travels and the defense gets Georgia off the field on third down, the averages get a vote.

Line and total: DraftKings via ESPN pickcenter, Oct. 27. Points for and against figured from ESPN's final scores; rushing, third-down and sack figures from ESPN 2026 team statistics (seven games each), Oct. 27.

BRENDEN MARTIN · WATCH

WE'RE LIVE: FLORIDA-GEORGIA TALK ON THE BUDDY MARTIN SHOW

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

The Buddy Martin Show is live Monday night, Oct. 26, with Florida-Georgia week on the agenda. Join Buddy for the conversation about Jon Sumrall's quarterback decision and the week ahead for the Gators.

WATCH THE SHOW LIVE

Tonight's episode, "Florida Gators: Sumrall Won't Name a QB for Georgia," is streaming on The Buddy Martin Show's YouTube channel. Tap

the watch link above to open the broadcast directly.

MORE FROM BUDDY

Read Buddy's new column: Florida-Georgia: Sumrall Knows the Math. He's Just Not Telling Georgia Who Takes the Snap.

Keep this article handy for the link to tonight's episode.

Photo courtesy UAA (University Athletic Association, FloridaGators.com) and Hannah White. See more of her work on Instagram, and the official Florida Gators photo galleries at FloridaGators.com.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: OCTOBER 26, 2026

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 26, 2026



Illustration: GatorBait Media.

A few thoughts to jump start your Monday morning:

That the Georgia Bulldogs are favored to beat the Florida Gators when the rivalry takes the first of a two-year vacation from its traditional home in Jacksonville is no surprise. The Bulldogs (6-1, 4-1 SEC) should be favored. They are ranked third in the latest Associated Press poll and have spent the year being touted as one of a handful of teams capable of running the College Football Playoff table to a national championship. Georgia's lone loss to Auburn is being dismissed as nothing more than a speed bump. Obviously, the people who set the point

spreads in Las Vegas share that belief, otherwise why else would they establish the Bulldogs as 10.5-point favorites to overwhelm 17th-ranked Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC) Saturday (3:30 p.m., ABC) at Atlanta's Mercedes-Benz Stadium?

It is a familiar narrative for Florida. Just a couple of weeks ago, the Gators opened the week as 10.5-point road underdogs to Texas. The spread swelled to 11.5 points by gametime in Austin. No way a Florida team that fell victim to spinning toe holds, atomic elbow drops and at least one reverse vertical suplex in consecutive losses to Missouri and South Carolina could hang with the mighty Longhorns, right?

Well, a funny thing happened on the way to the sleeper hold that was waiting in Austin. The Gators woke up, rose from the mat, and sprung a 27-24 upset over then No. 7 Texas, which a week before had been the No. 1 team in the nation. Something similar happened in Athens on the same day. Auburn was a 19.5-point underdog to then No. 1 Georgia but that same team Florida beat with a stunning offensive show of force back in September, leapt off the ring ropes to body slam Georgia's undefeated season dreams, ironically by a 27-24 score. Georgia, the team that overwhelmed

opponents by playing mistake-free football, couldn't stop Auburn's Byrum Brown from running over, under, around and through their vaunted defense and Gunner Stockton completed two passes to the Auburn defense and fumbled away the Bulldogs' chances to win the game.

So, here we are two weeks later from those rather unexpected developments, and the Gators are (a) once again 10.5-point underdogs to a higher-ranked team being touted as true national championship contenders; (b) considered incapable of matching the size and strength they'll see on both lines of scrimmage; and (c) uncertain if Tramell Jones Jr. will be making his second collegiate start at quarterback or if Aaron Philo's wounded shoulder has healed well enough to play. As Yogi Berra would say, "it's like déjà vu all over again," because those same points that made the idea of a win in Austin seem so improbable are the same ones being used to tout Georgia this week.

Can it happen again? Can the Florida Gators defy the odds and the hype to take down yet a third top ten opponent in the same season? It doesn't seem quite as impossible today as it seemed the Monday before Florida's win in Austin or Auburn's win over Georgia in Athens.

So ignore the pro-Georgia hype and remember the words of Dusty Rhodes: “I am the man of the hour, the man with the power. I am the hit-maker, the record-breaker. I got style and grace and a pretty face. I’ll make your back crack and your liver quiver!”

You gotta believe.

Associated Press top 25 (SEC teams bold face): 1. Miami 7-0; 2. Ohio State 6-1; 3. Georgia 6-1; 4. Indiana 7-1; 5. Notre Dame 6-1; 6. Utah 7-0; 7. UCLA 7-0; 8. BYU 6-1; 9. Kentucky 7-1; 10. Alabama 6-2; 11. Texas 5-2; 12. Ole Miss 5-2; 13. Texas Tech 6-1; 14. Wake Forest 6-1; 15. LSU 6-2; 16. Tennessee 6-2; 17. FLORIDA 5-2; 18. Houston 6-2; 19. SMU 6-1; 20. (TIE) Boise State 6-1; Northwestern 6-1; 22. Arizona 6-1; 23. Missouri 5-2; 24. Oklahoma State 5-2; 25. Wisconsin 5-2

AFCA Coaches top 25: 1. Miami 7-0; 2. Ohio State 6-1; 3. Georgia 6-1; 4. Indiana 7-1; 5. Utah 7-0; 6. Notre Dame 6-1; 7. UCLA 7-0; 8. Kentucky 7-1; 9. BYU 6-1; 10. Alabama 6-2; 11. Texas 5-2; 12. Ole Miss 5-2; 13. LSU 6-2; 14. Texas Tech 6-1; 15. Wake Forest 6-1; 16. SMU 6-1; 17. Tennessee 6-2; 18. Northwestern 6-1; 19. Houston 6-2; 20. FLORIDA 5-2; 21. Arizona 6-1; 22. Boise State 6-1; 23. Missouri 5-2; 24. Iowa 6-2; 25. Southern Cal 6-2

COUNTDOWN TO FIRING DAY: OCTOBER 26, 2026 EDITION

EXTINCT SPECIES LIST

Dave Aranda, Baylor: Baylor canned Aranda after a 25-24 loss to Kansas. The Bears are 4-3 with a schedule that has 6-6 written all over it. The Bears were 2-3 in games started by DJ Lagway, 2-0 in games started by Nate Bennett. Defensive coordinator Joe Klanderman is the interim head coach. Names you are likely to hear in the head coach search are Jeff Traylor (UT-San Antonio), GJ Kinne (Texas State), Zach Kittley (Florida Atlantic) and Minnesota Vikings QB coach Josh McCown.

Dave Doeren, North Carolina State: After 13+ years without a championship, Doeren was fired with a 3-4 record this year, 98-73 for his tenure at NCSU. He took the Wolfpack to 11 bowl games, but had just two second place division finishes. Running backs/special teams coordinator Todd Goebel is the interim head coach. The alumni favorite to replace Doeren is former Wolfpack QB Philip Rivers, who played 18 NFL seasons. Other names already being mentioned are James Madison coach Billy Napier, New Mexico coach Jason Eck, Indiana defensive coordinator Bryant Haines and Miami offensive coordinator Shannon Dawson.

Mike Locksley, Maryland: Among the names associated with the early coaching search at Maryland are Wake Forest coach Jake Dickert, New Mexico coach Jason Eck, UNLV coach Dan Mullen, Memphis coach Charles Huff Jr. and James Madison coach Billy Napier.

ON LIFE SUPPORT

Mike Norvell, Florida State: There is bad news and there is more bad news for Florida State. Another losing season and they think they'll find the money to buy out his contract. That's the bad news. The even worse news is if he wins, he stays another year. Nobody likes the choices. Clemson comes to Tallahassee this weekend.

Greg Schiano, Rutgers: It's not a question of if he gets pink slipped but simply a matter of when. The Scarlet Knights are 2-5, going nowhere and recruiting is dead end.

Deion Sanders, Colorado: The Buffs are 2-5, 0-4 in the Big 12. The Prime Time luster has worn off and he might not make it past Saturday if the Buffs take a hosing from Kansas State.

Joe Moorhead, Akron: The Zips are 1-7 this year and things will not get better. Moorhead works cheap but there comes a time to cut ties and now is the time.

ENDANGERED SPECIES LIST

Steve Sarkisian, Texas: Amazing what an unexpected win will do for you. Sark was On Life Support but drops down to Endangered thanks to the win over Ole Miss. The Texas AD will probably demand a new offensive coordinator and for Sark to relinquish play calling duties.

Brent Venables, Oklahoma: Okay, the Sooners beat Mississippi State in Starkville. The offense still stunk but the defense played well, as always. He's probably safe for another year as long as he agrees to get rid of offensive coordinator Ben Arbuckle.

Kalen DeBoer, Alabama: He has to run the table to finish 10-2 in the regular season before he's off the hook. Every regular season game from here on out is a College Football Playoff elimination game.

Tony Elliott, Virginia: He will survive this season no matter what, but he's 26-29, now in his sixth season at UVa with only one winning season to show for it.

Jedd Fisch, Washington: His career record is 36-36, 19-19 at Washington. The Huskies are 4-3 with a schedule that has a 7-5 feel to it. If the

Huskies go belly up the rest of the way, all bets are off.

ONE FINAL PITHY THOUGHT: Someone named Annette DeBella is credited for coining the phrase “karma’s a bitch” during a Philadelphia News interview back in 1992. At the time she said it, Annette DeBella and husband John DeBella were divorcing and engaged in a very public feud in which the insults were flying. Divorce too often has this habit of bringing out the narcissistic worst in the afflicted parties. It’s all about playing the role of the victim, therefore the sad state of affairs is always the fault of the other person.

Shortly after Jon Sumrall became Florida’s football coach there was a divorce that since turned rather nasty. Rather than go through the indignity of actually competing for the starting quarterback role, former 5-star and national high school player of the year DJ Lagway went into the portal and transferred to Baylor. Once in Waco, DJ started pointing fingers of blame at Florida where the adults let him down. Florida’s 4-8 record in 2025, those 14 interceptions, the countless open receivers either ignored or overthrown and the bad decisions that caused the Gators to lose football games couldn’t have possibly been his

fault, right? It wasn't his fault that his inconsistent play had a lot to do with Billy Napier getting fired, right?

The same issues that were a problem at Florida followed Lagway to Baylor. The bad mechanics that caused him so many misfires at Florida were never coached out of him at Baylor where he threw interceptions, missed or ignored open receivers and made so many bad decisions. Rather than the 7-0 record that could have been, Baylor is 4-3 and looking for a new head coach. Careful analysis of the three losses points 10 fingers of blame at Lagway who completed 69-138 passes for 825 yards with three touchdowns and three interceptions. A sign of things to come was his botched throw that should have been an easy game-winning touchdown against Auburn in game one.

In all fairness, Lagway's 12-12 record as a starting quarterback over three seasons at Florida and Baylor isn't totally his fault. It is a team game after all and teammates have to pick up the slack even when the quarterback's passes can't find the ocean from the end of the pier. Still, this is two straight coaches who pinned their job security on DJ Lagway and both of them have been fired.

If whoever is hired as Baylor's new coach decides a divorce is necessary, you have to wonder if (a) there is a school in a power conference willing to take a chance on Lagway; and (b) if he goes somewhere else will Lagway bite his tongue or blame everyone else for his own failures?

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

BRENDEN MARTIN · GAME WEEK

FLORIDA-GEORGIA WEEK: ATLANTA KICKOFF, QUARTERBACK WATCH AND FAN PLANS

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 25, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

Florida and Georgia return from open dates Saturday, Oct. 31, with their annual rivalry moving to Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Kickoff is set for 3:30 p.m. ET on ABC, giving Gators fans a week to follow the quarterback story and plan for a different game-day destination.

Florida is 5-2 overall and 3-2 in the SEC. Georgia is 6-1 and 4-1. Both last played Oct. 17: Florida won 27-24 at Texas, while Kirby Smart's Bulldogs lost 27-24 at home to Auburn.

Monday's first public stop is Gator Talk. Florida coach Jon Sumrall joins broadcaster Sean Kelley from 7-8 p.m. at The Swamp Restaurant, 1104 SW Second Ave. in Gainesville. Fans can attend or listen through Gator Sports Network affiliates, the Florida Gators app or the Varsity Network app.

Tramell Jones Jr. supplies the backdrop for this week's quarterback coverage. In his first college start at Texas, Jones completed 22 of 35 passes for 155 yards and two touchdowns and ran for 41 yards. UF's Oct. 21 account said Jones started after Aaron Philo was sidelined by a shoulder injury.

"I'm proud of him for staying resilient," Sumrall said after the Texas win.

UF's Oct. 21 feature described Florida's quarterback outlook as unsettled entering the bye week. It did not name a starter for Georgia. The Texas performance gives Jones a full game of starting experience to build on.

For the broader injury and scheduling discussion, Buddy Martin examines the physical toll of the SEC's nine-game schedule in his latest column.

The scene shifts to International Plaza in Atlanta on Friday, Oct. 30. The Paul Finebaum Show is scheduled there from 3-7 p.m. ET, according to UF's game-week programming announcement.

On Saturday, SEC Nation runs from 9 a.m. to noon ET on SEC Network from the same location. Former Florida quarterback Tim Tebow is part of the show's lineup. Marty & McGee follows live from International Plaza from noon to 12:45 p.m.

The game is in Atlanta while Jacksonville's EverBank Stadium undergoes construction. Georgia is the designated home team. Fans traveling to the game should use the stadium's current event guide for parking and bag policies. The venue lists gates opening at 2 p.m., 90 minutes before kickoff.

Get free GatorBait email updates. Sign up voluntarily and confirm your email to receive GatorBait Magazine and Florida Gators news. You can unsubscribe anytime.

Schedule, records and programming from FloridaGators.com and Georgia Athletics; venue information from Mercedes-Benz Stadium and the City of Jacksonville.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

BUDDY MARTIN

THE NINTH GAME IS COLLECTING ITS TOLL, ONE BODY AT A TIME

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 25, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Florida-Georgia used to be about who wanted it more. On Oct. 31 in Atlanta, it may come down to who has more players who can still walk without a limp.

They called it the World's Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party. This year it may be the World's Largest Outdoor Training Room. Bring your own ice.

In Gainesville, the bye week showed up like a cold towel on a hot neck. Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC) beat No. 7 Texas, then spent Saturday on the

couch. Best break Jon Sumrall has caught all month.

The Gators were ranked 17th in the latest AP poll. Miami held on to the No. 1 ranking.

THIS WEEK'S AP TOP 25

1. Miami (Fla.)
2. Ohio State
3. Georgia
4. Indiana
5. Notre Dame
6. Utah
7. UCLA
8. BYU
9. Kentucky
10. Alabama
11. Texas
12. Ole Miss
13. Texas Tech
14. Wake Forest
15. LSU
16. Tennessee

17. Florida

18. Houston

19. SMU

20. Boise State (tie)

20. Northwestern (tie)

22. Arizona

23. Missouri

24. Oklahoma State

25. Wisconsin

FLORIDA'S INJURY PICTURE

Aaron Philo took a shot to his throwing shoulder against South Carolina. Sumrall called it a "couple week deal," and Philo is questionable. Meanwhile, Tramell Jones Jr. made his first career start and beat the seventh-ranked team in the country. Sumrall hasn't announced who starts.

Vernell Brown III, Florida's leading receiver, hasn't played since a low-grade knee strain against Ole Miss on Sept. 26. Sumrall said he feels "really good about where he is." Brown is questionable. Bailey Stockton has been fighting a lower back injury since what Sumrall called "basically a car crash on the field with

two guys." Eric Singleton Jr. (ankle) is healing, and running back Duke Clark (foot) is a question mark.

With Brown out, redshirt freshman Dallas Wilson became the main target. It's a receiver room held together with tape and faith, but it's holding.

GEORGIA'S INJURY PICTURE

Up in Athens, Kirby Smart is doing the same thing with more tape.

Georgia (6-1, 4-1 SEC) limped into its open date after a 27-24 home loss to Auburn, and Smart didn't dress it up: "It seems that we're more beat up than we've been in the past."

That's the most buttoned-up coach in America, a man who would rather give up his playbook than an injury report. Believe him.

All-American safety KJ Bolden hurt his right leg against Alabama and watched Auburn in a walking boot. "We're hopeful to get him back," Smart said. Translation: nobody knows. Quarterback Gunner Stockton left on the first play against Auburn with a shoulder stinger.

None of that has scared the market. As of Sunday morning, Polymarket had Florida as a 10.5-point underdog, with the total at 55.5.

Georgia has won five straight in the series and eight of the last nine, and leads it 57-44-2 by Florida's count. Georgia says 58. The two schools can't even agree on how many times they've beaten each other up.

AROUND THE SEC

And Florida and Georgia are hardly the only ones counting bodies.

Arch Manning got up Saturday night. Ole Miss end Kam Franklin hit him hard enough that an independent medical examiner sent him to the sideline. Then Manning came back, plunged in for the go-ahead touchdown, and Texas survived, 34-27.

Survived is the right word. Now count the bodies.

Left tackle Trevor Goosby, a preseason All-American, was carted off holding his left knee. Star receiver Cam Coleman landed on his left shoulder and was soon on the sideline in street clothes, which is never the outfit you want.

"Obviously, neither of them look very good," Steve Sarkisian said. When a coach says that after a win, start bracing for Monday.

Colin Simmons, the nation's sack leader, is out about three weeks with a high ankle sprain. And Goosby's replacement got beat on the strip-sack touchdown that started the Rebels' comeback. One injury turned into three.

Ole Miss limped home too. Tailback Kewan Lacy reinjured his left shoulder and left on a cart. "He was in a lot of pain," Pete Golding said. "Same shoulder."

THE COST OF A NINTH GAME

This is what the SEC paid for. The league wanted nine conference games, and in 2026 it got them. Gone is the cupcake parked in mid-October, the sorry directional school that let the bruises fade while the band played. Add prime-time kickoffs that put players to bed at 2 a.m., and the recovery window is about as wide as a Kirby Smart smile.

Lane Kiffin said it in September, after LSU's Whit Weeks broke his leg: "Be careful what you wish for, SEC."

People rolled their eyes, because Kiffin always has an angle. It reads more like a forecast every week. Last Wednesday, Oklahoma listed 13 players as out, doubtful or questionable. Ole Miss and Alabama had 10 each. Those aren't injury reports. They're casualty lists.

Everybody wanted more big games. TV wanted them, and so did the guy in the end-zone suite with the pastel golf shirt. Nobody asked the 19- and 20-year-olds who play nine league games with no breather, then a title game, then a playoff. Nobody asked the guys on the cart.

And November hasn't even started.

So go ahead and check the line. Then check the injury report. Florida-Georgia won't be decided by who wants it more this year. It'll be decided by who's left standing.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

FRANZ BEARD

THE GATORS STILL HAVE A PULSE AFTER SATURDAY'S CHAOS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 25, 2026



Illustration: GatorBait Media.

The obituary was being penned and haggling had begun to get the right price for the coffin. That was three weeks ago when plans were in progress to lay Florida's 2026 football season to rest. That was before all hell broke loose not only in the Southeastern Conference but in college football nationwide.

The Gators beat Texas, Auburn beat Georgia and Tennessee beat Alabama. That was two Saturdays ago when the Gators rediscovered their pulse and suddenly found themselves

back in contention for both the SEC Championship Game and the College Football Playoff.

The Gators' chances got a boost yesterday when both Ole Miss and Tennessee were tagged with their second loss, leaving upstart Kentucky and Georgia as the only one-loss teams in the conference. The Gators are among the eight teams still in contention with two losses. For Florida and everyone else in the pack every game from here on out is an elimination game.

The way things are shaping up for the playoff the only way a three-loss team makes it to the College Football Playoff is to suffer the third loss in the conference championship game.

Prior to Saturday's chaos, the 12-team CFP was shaping up for three teams each from the SEC, Big Ten and Big 12 with the bracket filled out by Miami, Notre Dame and the highest rated conference champ from the Group of Six.

Then UCF stunned No. 2 BYU and No. 8 Texas Tech was whacked by Cincinnati, leaving Utah on top of the league and one of three remaining unbeaten teams in the country (Miami and UCLA are the other two). Rather than three teams in the CFP, the Big 12 might land only one.

If the Big 12 cannibalizes itself, the door could swing wide open for both the SEC and Big Ten to sneak a fourth team into the playoff picture. If Notre Dame loses to Miami, would the playoff committee pick a two-loss Notre Dame over a two-loss team that had run the SEC scheduling gauntlet?

Among the two-loss teams in the SEC, Florida is the only one with two wins over then top ten teams (Ole Miss and Texas). Beating Georgia, which seemed a teensy bit hallucinogenic three weeks ago seems do-able now. By the time the Gators travel to Kentucky, the Wildcats could be staring down their first SEC championship since they shared it with Georgia in 1976 and before that, 1950, a couple years before they ran Bear Bryant off.

Could the Gators pull it off? Stranger things have happened and it should be lost on no one that Jon Sumrall has played for four consecutive conference championships (two at Troy, two at Tulane). The Gators would have to win their next five games to make the SEC Championship Game. Difficult for sure. Impossible? Maybe but maybe not. Sumrall has had winning streaks of 10 and 11 games during his career so he knows what it takes to get a team on a roll.

Three weeks ago we wouldn't have even given a second thought to the notion that the Gators could make the playoff. That was then. This is now. For the moment, at least, it does seem possible.

SEC CONTENDERS (TEAMS WITH ONE OR TWO LOSSES)

NO. 12 KENTUCKY (7-1, 5-1 SEC)

The Wildcats are living large in rarefied air but the three games after the bye week will determine if they're contenders or pretenders.

Saturday: Open. Other remaining games: at No. 11 Tennessee; No. 20 Florida; at No. 22 Missouri and Louisville.

NO. 5 GEORGIA (6-1, 4-1 SEC)

Georgia is capable of running the table. The Bulldogs are also capable of losing two of the next three.

Saturday: No. 20 Florida in Atlanta; Other remaining games: at No. 7 Ole Miss. Other remaining games: No. 22 Missouri; at South Carolina and Georgia Tech.

NO. 13 ALABAMA (6-2, 4-2 SEC)

Get past LSU in two weeks and Alabama has one of the easier paths to the playoff.

Saturday: Open. Other remaining games: at No. 18 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC); at Vanderbilt; Chattanooga and Auburn.

NO. 20 FLORIDA (5-2, 3-2 SEC)

This isn't rocket science. Just win the next five games and the Gators are in the College Football Playoff and perhaps even the SEC Championship Game.

Saturday: No. 5 Georgia in Atlanta. Other remaining games: Oklahoma; at No. 12 Kentucky; Vanderbilt; at Florida State.

NO. 7 OLE MISS (5-2, 3-2 SEC)

The only ranked team remaining is No. 5 Georgia in two weeks. Otherwise it is a do-able schedule.

Saturday: Auburn. Other remaining games: at No. 5 Georgia; at Oklahoma; Wofford; Mississippi State.

NO. 11 TENNESSEE (6-2, 3-2 SEC)

The game with Kentucky in two weeks is an elimination game for the Vols.

Saturday: Open. Other remaining games: No. 12 Kentucky; at Texas A&M; No. 18 LSU; at Vanderbilt.

NO. 18 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC)

Nobody has a more difficult schedule than the Fighting Kiffins. The next three games are brutal.

Saturday: Open. Other remaining games: No. 13 Alabama; No. 19 Texas; at No. 11 Tennessee; at Arkansas.

NO. 19 TEXAS (5-2, 2-2 SEC)

Saturday: Mississippi State. Other remaining games: at No. Missouri; at No. 18 LSU; Arkansas; at Texas A&M.

NO. 22 MISSOURI (5-2, 2-2 SEC)

Saturday: at Arkansas. Other remaining games: at No. 5 Georgia; No. 12 Kentucky; Oklahoma.

OKLAHOMA (4-3, 2-2 SEC)

Saturday: South Carolina. Other remaining games: at FLORIDA; No. 7 Ole Miss; Texas A&M; at No. 22 Missouri

SEC PRETENDERS (THREE OR MORE LOSSES)

Mississippi State (4-3, 2-3 SEC); Auburn (4-3, 2-3 SEC); South Carolina (4-3, 2-3 SEC); Arkansas (3-4, 1-3 SEC); Texas A&M (4-4, 1-4 SEC); Vanderbilt (3-5, 0-5 SEC)

SATURDAY IN THE SEC

NO. 19 TEXAS (5-2, 2-2 SEC) 34, NO. 7 OLE MISS (5-2, 3-2 SEC) 27

Texas built a 24-3 lead at the half, then held on for dear life to remain in contention for as Arch Manning played the best two quarters of his collegiate career. In the first half, Manning connected with Ryan Wingo for a 50-yard touchdown pass and ran for another TD. The defense, meanwhile, held Ole Miss to 139 first half yards while keeping the Rebels out of the end zone.

SOUTH CAROLINA (4-3, 2-3 SEC) 27, NO. 11 TENNESSEE (6-2, 3-2 SEC) 24

Dylan Stewart hit Tennessee quarterback George MacIntyre, forcing a fumble that teammate Tomiway Durojaiye recovered with 33 seconds remaining, setting up Malik Orsan's game-winning 48-yard walk-off field goal.

South Carolina tied the game at 24-24 with 2:18 left in the game when LaNorris Sellers capped a six-play, 61-yard scoring drive with a four-yard touchdown run. Sellers was sacked five times but still threw for 210 yards and a TD and ran for 96 and two TDs as the Gamecocks knocked off their second straight ranked team.

NO. 12 KENTUCKY (7-1, 5-1 SEC) 34, VANDERBILT (3-5, 0-5 SEC) 17

The Wildcats outscored Vandy 20-7 in the second half to remain at the top of the SEC standings and probably crack the top ten for the first time since 2022 when they made it up to No. 7 before absorbing a loss to Ole Miss. Kentucky's defense eliminated Vanderbilt's run game (15 yards), forcing the Commodores to throw every down. Kentucky converted 8-13 on third down, kept the chains moving and prevented the Commodores from mounting a comeback.

NO. 13 ALABAMA (6-2, 4-2 SEC) 31, TEXAS A&M (4-4, 1-4 SEC) 20

Keelon Russell threw two touchdown passes in the fourth quarter to lead Alabama to a come from behind win over Texas A&M. Trailing 20-17 going into the fourth quarter, Russell connected with Marshall Pritchett from five yards out for the go-ahead touchdown and sealed the win with an eight-yard TD pass to Kaleb Edwards.

Russell finished the game with 311 passing yards for three touchdowns. Dijon Lee had a 39-yard pick six in the first quarter, his second TD on an interception return this season and

the sixth defensive touchdown of the season for Alabama. The Aggies were held to 278 yards by the Alabama defense.

Aggie QB Marcel Reed threw two interceptions and fumbled three times, losing one.

NO. 18 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC) 38, AUBURN (4-3, 2-3 SEC) 17

LSU sacked Byrum Brown seven times while holding Auburn to a single touchdown and 204 yards of offense. Brown, whose mobility was the critical factor in Auburn's upset of Georgia last week, was credited with 21 rushing yards on 19 attempts.

Meanwhile Sam Leavitt threw for 387 yards and three touchdowns while running for 54 and another TD as LSU racked up 552 offensive yards. LSU is the only team in the country that ranks top ten in both total offense and total defense.

OKLAHOMA (4-3, 2-2 SEC) 23, MISSISSIPPI STATE (4-3, 2-3 SEC) 15

First and foremost, John Mateer didn't throw an interception. Secondly, Oklahoma ran for 184 yards. Combine that with Kamario Taylor tried but couldn't get past the first quarter and you have in a nutshell how it is Oklahoma won on the road in Starkville. Mateer threw two

touchdown passes, one of them to Isaac Sategna, who caught eight for 164 yards. Fluff Bothwell returned for Mississippi State, gaining 111 yards on 17 carries, but it wasn't enough.

Original illustration: GatorBait Media.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

FRANZ BEARD · THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

SUMRALL RESTORES HOPE AS TEXAS FACES A RECKONING

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 24, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Thoughts of the Day | Oct. 24, 2026

A few thoughts to jump-start your Saturday morning:

Confession time. In the privacy of your own home with no one to witness, raise your hand if you thought two weeks ago that the Florida Gators would be most fortunate to limp home with a 6-6 regular season? Losing to Missouri and South Carolina in thank you sir may I have another fashion will do that to you.

Memories of Mizzou and South Carolina are in the rearview after the upset of Texas in Austin and the bye week has provided necessary time for Florida's walking wounded to heal up in time for the five-week gauntlet ahead. Have the last two weeks pumped hope back into the collective mindset of the Gator Nation? Or, is it because next up is Georgia next Saturday in Atlanta that you are tempering your expectations?

Fair questions that deserve honest answers.

Bunch me in with the doubters, especially after the way the Gators were skewered and rotisseried by the Gamecocks at The Swamp. Losing to Missouri wasn't necessarily a surprise given the way the Gators seem to always dial up crappy when they travel to Columbia. Even a 28-point loss could be rationalized to a certain degree. But blown out by the Chickens on national TV in The Swamp?

That had me thinking 6-6 likely, 7-5 if the offensive line could remember it's legal to block somebody wearing a different-colored shirt and the defense discovered that it is okay to get off the field on third down. Then came Texas and that 15-play drive that took more than eight minutes off the third-quarter clock. Once the Gators fell behind 17-3, the defense

went beast mode, turning Arch Manning and the Texas offense into a generic version of corn flakes. You know the type. Crispy until the milk turns them soggy.

Hope is once again whizzing through my veins. Eight wins? Not only doable but an achievement since it will be doubling up on last year's four-win total. Nine? Not out of the question. Impossible without a win over Georgia or Kentucky but as Auburn proved to Georgia and Alabama to Kentucky, if you are vulnerable you can be had.

I'm not even going to think about getting to 10 wins. That would mean running the table but before dismissing that as a possibility, I can't overlook that Jon Sumrall had win streaks of 11 and 10 games in his two years at Troy, eight and five in his two years at Tulane. He is 48-14 counting the 5-2 at Florida this season. To paraphrase Curt Cignetti, he wins. Google it.

Some may dismiss this as another case of sunshine pumping on my part, but I started writing about college football in 1967. I've been around. Experience tells me certain coaches have this aura about them. I am reminded of the late, great Bum Phillips and his awe of Bear Bryant. Bum said, "He could take his'n and beat yours, and take yours and beat his'n." Wherever

he was, whatever the circumstance, whoever his players were, Bear Bryant won. Something about Sumrall gives me a similar feeling.

I admit, I wanted Lane Kiffin. I think everybody did. All the things Lane says that cause us to shake our heads we would be defending right now if he were the Florida coach. He's only outrageous when he's coaching somewhere else. If he were a Gator we would be saying he's Spurrier, Part Deux.

But Lane is at LSU where he's probably going to win a national championship when all is said and done. Jon Sumrall is at Florida and I couldn't be happier. Starting with his first press conference, he's grown on me and continues to grow on me. He doesn't sugarcoat things. He speaks his mind. He demands accountability from his coaches, his players and everyone associated with the program. He takes personal responsibility when everyone else around him comes up short of expectations.

I think he's the right coach at the right time and for all any of us know, he just might win a national championship here before Lane Kiffin wins one at LSU. Wouldn't that be a hoot?

URBAN MEYER ON THE FLAW IN THE 24-TEAM PLAYOFF

Like it or not – I don't – the 24-team College Football Playoff era is upon us, maybe as soon as next year. I may warm to the eventuality of playoff expansion but for now I'm stuck in the Stone Age.

Urban Meyer, while admitting the 24-team playoff concept has grown on him to the point of acceptance, laments that expansion isn't without consequences.

On his Triple Option podcast, Meyer said, "The only concern I have, and I'll keep saying this as long as I'm around, those who say that conference championship games are not important, I will say never played in it, never coached in it, and never won a ring … Conference championship games are one of the most exciting things that ever happened in my lifetime, and certainly for my players. And they're gone. They're gone."

ONE FINAL PITHY THOUGHT

Texas athletic director Chris Del Conte spent a portion of his Friday trying to convince the civilized world that everything is just peachy on The 40 Acres, which is what Texas calls the campus in Austin. Sark is just fine. Arch

couldn't be better. Life could be a dream. The only people who don't think so are the ones who don't live in Austin.

He was selling hard. Not so sure how many are buying, certainly not those of us living in the real world. And how many of the folks living in Austin are happy that, despite all the cold, hard cash the faithful have poured into football, the Longhorns find themselves on the brink of playoff elimination?

Life could be a dream is the Del Conte message and yes, should the Longhorns whip up on Ole Miss tonight and run the rest of the regular season table they will be sitting pretty at 10-2, virtually assured of the College Football Playoff. Do that and Steve Sarkisian goes from overhyped and time to leave to conquering hero who should hang around awhile.

Nightmares are dreams, too. If you ignore the peachy keen rhetoric, instead taking the I live in the real world approach, a nightmare is what Texas will have if it gets kicked in the crotch by Ole Miss tonight. Thanks to the Big 12 which could have two unbeatens and another two one-loss teams in the regular season, the Southeastern Conference probably only gets

three teams in the playoff, none of which will have three losses. So tonight is an elimination game for the Longhorns.

As if the idea of missing the playoff isn't pressure enough, there is the Manning factor. Ole Miss is where Archie and Eli Manning played college football. The entire Manning clan with the exception of Peyton, who the faithful whisper was dropped on his head too many times as an infant, thus explaining why he went to Tennessee, is Ole Miss royalty. Texas has to win this game for obvious reasons, but Arch Manning has to play lights out to uphold the Manning honor. If Arch flames out like he did against Oklahoma and Florida, it will be like tossing a couple of those NASCAR pitstop cans filled with gas on the bonfire that is already raging back in Austin.

Here is the kicker to this narrative. Had Arch chosen Ole Miss instead of Texas back when he was the consensus No. 1 high school quarterback in the country, it is highly unlikely that Trinidad Chambliss would have wound up in Oxford. Trinidad is the nation's best quarterback, whose journey to Ole Miss is routed through Division II Ferris State in Michigan. On his average to bad days he's still better than Arch is on his good ones. On his good days, Trinidad Chambliss performs like it's

a Heisman Trophy audition. With him at QB, Ole Miss might win the national championship. He's that good.

Would Arch have developed at Ole Miss? He certainly hasn't developed under Steve Sarkisian who seems destined for a pink slip in the event of a loss tonight. The next and most painful question that begs to be asked: Is Arch Manning simply the worst of the Manning quarterbacks? Secondly, can his career be rehabbed?

If Sark loses tonight everything won't be peachy in Burnt Orange Country. If you believe the rumblings from the boosters that echo from sea to shining sea, Sark is a goner if he loses to Ole Miss. The last two games have exposed Arch's lack of football common sense. His inconsistent football instincts are why he has gone from a candidate to be the overall No. 1 draft pick next April to desperately needs another year of college football to see if the rough edges can be smoothed out. Will he stay at Texas if Sark is fired? Ole Miss will need a QB next year. As blasphemous as it sounds, would Ole Miss even welcome Arch if he entered the portal?

This is football's version of the soap opera. If Days of Our Lives had plots like this it would still be on network TV instead of streaming.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

FRANZ BEARD · THE SOOTHSAYER

FLORIDA-GEORGIA OUTLOOK AND SEC PICKS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 23, 2026



Collage: GatorBait Media; photos by Chris Spears and courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

Vernell Brown III at The Swamp, and Tramell Jones Jr. handing off to Jadan Baugh against Texas in Austin. Brown photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media; Jones/Baugh photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White. Editorial collage by GatorBait Media.

Thoughts of the Day · October 23, 2026

A few thoughts to jump start your Friday morning:

Traditionally, both Florida and Georgia have a bye week prior to their close encounter, usually in Jacksonville but in Atlanta this year, Tampa next while EverBank Stadium is renovated. No

one could have possibly foreseen just how perfect the timing of the bye week would be for Jon Sumrall, whose 20th-ranked Gators (5-2, 3-2 SEC) have used the open date to heal their banged up wide receiver corps. Getting Vernell Brown III, Eric Singleton Jr. and Bailey Stockton as close to full speed as possible enhances the Gators' chances to spring the upset on the 5th-ranked Bulldogs (6-1, 4-1 SEC), who were exposed as vulnerable by Auburn, a team the Gators beat.

The extra week also benefits Florida quarterback Aaron Philo, who took a blow to his throwing shoulder in the loss to South Carolina and missed the Gators' upset of Texas. It is said to be either a bruised or sprained AC joint. Best-case scenario for healing: three to four weeks. Worst case, out the rest of the year. The game at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta will be week three in the healing process. Enough time for Philo to be healthy enough to play? Only time will answer that question.

Meanwhile, Tramell Jones Jr. has a Texas scalp under his belt and he's preparing in earnest to earn his spot in Gator lore if he's able to take down a second top-10 team in just his second start. He rallied the Gators from 14 down to win

against that fierce Texas defense and he did it without Brown and with Singleton and Stockton both slowed by injuries.

Whether it's Philo or Jones taking the snaps, if all the receivers are at or near 100 percent the idea that the Gators could beat Georgia doesn't seem as preposterous an idea as it might have only a few weeks ago.

THE SEC SOOTHSAYER

NO. 7 OLE MISS (5-1, 3-1 SEC) AT NO. 19 TEXAS (4-2, 1-2 SEC)

7:30 p.m., ABC

This could one day be known as Sark's Last Stand. Lose and the Longhorns, for all practical purposes, are left sitting on the curb while a whole bunch of College Football Playoff contenders go whizzing by. Lose, and for all practical purposes, Steve Sarkisian is a dead man walking.

Texas lost to Florida and a backup QB making his first collegiate start last week.

This week the Longhorns get to face probably the best college football quarterback in the country in Trinidad Chambliss, who has the

luxury once again of handing the ball off to Kewan Lacy, finally healthy and running over, under, around and through people.

Texas has to hope that Arch Manning will be inspired by the idea of beating the alma mater of Hall of Fame relatives, grandfather Archie and uncle Eli. The Ole Miss defense just held Missouri to a three-spot. The Rebels are good enough to win this one by a couple of touchdowns if they don't turn the ball over.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: Here's something to rattle around in your brains. Ole Miss wins, Sark gets fired and at the end of the season, Arch hears Mama call and transfers to Ole Miss where he can get coached up (finally!) and restore the honor of the Manning name. Texas is somehow a 3.5-point favorite. It's not because of Arch but because of Will Muschamp's defense. Doesn't matter. Ole Miss is going to emerge the winner.

NO. 11 TENNESSEE (6-1, 3-1 SEC) AT SOUTH CAROLINA (3-3, 1-3 SEC)

3:30 p.m., ESPN

Something seems very wrong here. The Vols are coming off a dominant 25-10 win over Alabama, a no doubter if ever there was one.

Yet, here we are a week later and they're 2.5-point underdogs on the road at Willy Brice where the Chickens had a bye week.

Do the experts think LaNorris Sellers awakened from a coma when he led South Carolina to a decisive win over Florida in The Swamp? That's what it will take for South Carolina to win this one, but if they do stick it to the Vols, it is very likely Shane Beamer will be coaching in Columbia again next year.

When the Chickens beat Florida, they stuffed the run and made the Florida passing game very ordinary. Something along those lines will be necessary along with Sellers escaping the UT pass rush, which leads the nation with 30 sacks.

Can the Vols run the football? If they can't they're going to lose.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: It's really tempting to pick an upset here but the way Tennessee played last week against Alabama says no way. However, if it is close at the end of the third quarter, all bets are off.

VANDERBILT (3-4, 0-4 SEC) AT NO. 12 KENTUCKY (6-1, 4-1 SEC)

7:30 p.m., SEC Network

The way Will Stein has the Wildcats playing, the UK faithful need to be ordering Ted Lasso "Believe" T-shirts and sweatshirts in bulk. If Kentucky beats Vanderbilt Saturday evening, the Wildcats will have guaranteed their first winning season since 2023.

For all the talk about how Stein has rejuvenated the UK offense, it's the defense that is actually stealing the show. The Wildcats lead the SEC in turnover margin. Vanderbilt is learning what life is like with a true freshman quarterback in the SEC. Jared Curtis is going to be a fine quarterback someday. Just not Saturday.

Vandy fans must be wondering how it is that Kentucky basketball player Franck Kepnang got a seventh year from the NCAA and Diego Pavia didn't get a seventh (or is it eighth) to play football at Vanderbilt? The Commodores are a 10.5-point underdog in Lexington. It feels like that number is way too small.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: A win would certainly change the mood on Nashville's West End where folks are thinking we're back to being Vandy again after winning 10 games last year. The Commodores will be fortunate to find another win on their schedule, so 3-9 is highly likely. Something about this one says Kentucky wins in a blowout.

TEXAS A&M (4-3, 1-3 SEC) AT NO. 13 ALABAMA (5-2, 3-2 SEC)

3:30 p.m., ABC

Is there a more disappointing team in the SEC than the Aggies? And, is there a more disappointing QB in the entire country than Marcel Reed? With that being said, this is a chance for both the Aggies and Reed to right a listing ship. Can they spring the upset? A week ago the answer would have been no, not a chance and hell no.

That was before Alabama got thoroughly exposed by Tennessee's defense which sacked Keelon Russell five times, held the Tide to 54 rushing yards, forced four turnovers and allowed only 10 points.

Mike Elko's rep is that of a defensive genius. Can he get the Aggies to replicate what Tennessee did? Can Marcel Reed remember it's not nice to turn the ball over?

As for Alabama, this is an elimination game, for the team's hopes of the College Football Playoff and perhaps for Kalen DeBoer's hopes of being gainfully employed in Tuscaloosa next year. A third loss this season will be his eleventh in three years. Bama fans are quick to tell you Nick never did that.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: This just reeks of an upset even though the Aggies have found themselves on the blowout end of two of their three SEC losses. The Aggies are 13.5-point underdogs and Alabama will be without its most explosive offensive player, wide receiver Ryan Coleman-Williams. If Alabama still has a Tennessee hangover, it will be low tide in Tuscaloosa. Fortunately for Alabama, Marcel Reed is the opposing QB, but it's going to be a chest clutcher at the end.

NO. 18 LSU (5-2, 2-2 SEC) AT AUBURN (4-2, 2-2 SEC)

12 noon, ABC

This may turn out to be the best game of the day. LSU's defense pitched a shutout last week at Mississippi State while Auburn QB Byrum Brown was too hot for Georgia to handle in Athens. LSU is giving up only 88 yards per game on the ground and has sacked quarterbacks 27 times.

Sam Leavitt is starting to play like the QB he was hyped to be when he transferred in from Arizona State. None of that bodes well for Auburn, which ranks dead last in the SEC and 134th nationally in sacks allowed.

Florida sacked Brown seven times. Georgia got to Brown five times last week, but he escaped enough times to lead Auburn to a shocking win.

He needs to be in his feets don't fail me now mode against LSU and Auburn's defense needs to play as well as it did last week when it forced three critical Georgia turnovers.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: It's an elimination game for LSU, which has to win the next five games to have a shot at the College Football Playoff. For Auburn, it's a chance to prove the win over Georgia wasn't a fluke and that first-year coach Alex Golesh has the Tigers headed onward and upward. Lane Kiffin knows what it takes to motivate a team when its back is to the wall. LSU is favored by a TD. White knuckles at the end and Lane gets a win.

OKLAHOMA (3-3, 1-2 SEC) AT MISSISSIPPI STATE (4-2, 2-2 SEC)

3:30 p.m., SEC Network

Oklahoma is sticking with John Mateer at quarterback. If Kamario Taylor and Fluff Bothwell can't go for Mississippi State, Mateer might be the Bulldogs' secret weapon due to his penchant for completing passes to the other team.

Oklahoma has a world-class defense that held Kentucky to 230 yards last week. If Mateer and the offense had cooperated, the Sooners would have won the game.

Without Taylor and Bothwell, Mississippi State's offense is on the same plane as Oklahoma.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: Oklahoma is a 5.5-point favorite, largely due to the likelihood Taylor and Bothwell won't play. The Bulldogs are an explosive team with their two studs. Without them, they will go down in what promises to be an ugly game from start to finish.

ONE FINAL PITHY THOUGHT

There is a theory out there, most recently promoted by Arizona basketball coach Tommy Lloyd and embraced by Gary Parrish of CBS, the best basketball writer in the country, that the NCAA is actually promoting the chaos that it claims will result from 2022 high school grads getting a fifth year of eligibility. Bear with me on this one. It's complicated but logical.

It goes something like this: The NCAA, in its infinite wisdom, claims that 2022 high school grads are excluded from a fifth year of eligibility because (a) it will create fewer

opportunities for incoming freshmen and (b) a coach adding a 2022 grad to his roster will in turn cut a player already on scholarship. Therefore, chaos! Florida coach Todd Golden debunked that defense more than a week ago.

Meanwhile, 2022 athletes who feel unfairly left out by the NCAA have taken to the courts where they are winning injunctions that will make them eligible. The NCAA is appealing their injunctions and in some cases getting a stay of the players' temporary restraining orders. Millions of billable hours for attorneys and players' lives held hostage.

The NCAA, of course, could give up the appeals and simply grandfather the players in, making them eligible to play. So why doesn't that happen? This is where Lloyd and Parrish chime in – it is because the NCAA is trying to create the chaos it claims to be fighting for the purpose of taking a cattle prod to Congress to pass the Protect College Sports Act.

"I think my theory is this thing has gotten so political – and, obviously, there are a lot of things that need to be fixed in college sports," Lloyd said. "So [in my opinion,] the NCAA doesn't mind the 'chaos' right now because it

can help drive the case for them to promote the [Protect] College Sports Act, which I'm sure we need."

Translation: The NCAA is so out of control it needs an act of Congress to stabilize things and it's willing to sacrifice the players it claims to protect to get the outside help it HOPES will save its control.

What we really need is something other than the NCAA, but unfortunately no one has a Plan B for a brand new organization that will enforce its own rules fairly.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

BUDDY MARTIN · SEC LEGENDS

FROM THE SCOUT TEAM TO ATLANTA: CHRIS DOERING FINALLY GETS HIS DUE

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 23, 2026



Photo: UAA/SEC.

He left in 1995 with 31 touchdown catches, still the school record and second in SEC history. Think about the receivers who have come through Gainesville since then

By Buddy Martin

They used to hand Chris Doering a scout-team jersey and tell him to go get hit. He'd take the beating, show up the next day, and take it again. No scholarship or promise came with it, and nobody in Gainesville was printing his name in the program.

He was a skinny kid from P.K. Yonge whose dream was bigger than his resume. Thirty-five years later, that kid is an SEC Legend. Doering was named Thursday last week to the 2026 SEC Football Legends class.

It's a 16-member group full of Heisman Trophy winners, national champions and NFL stars: Nick Saban of Alabama, Mark Richt of Georgia, Billy Sims of Oklahoma, Patrick Peterson of LSU, Randall Cobb of Kentucky and Ricky Williams of Texas.

The walk-on is standing in that crowd. Tell me this game doesn't still make room for a good story.

"THE SCARLET LETTER"

You have to understand how much that label stung. "I hated being called a walk-on," Doering told me on The Buddy Martin Show. "It was such a scarlet letter to me. It always felt like it was

just less than everybody else. So I wanted that validation of having a scholarship. It meant more to me when I finally got it."

So he tore it off. Doering walked on for Steve Spurrier in 1991 and had a scholarship before his sophomore season. Nobody gave it to him. He took it, one scout-team rep at a time. Then he went out and rewrote the Florida record book.

He left in 1995 with 31 touchdown catches, still the school record and second in SEC history. Think about the receivers who have come through Gainesville since then. None of them has caught him.

He finished with 149 catches for more than 2,000 yards. His senior season was something special: 70 catches, 1,045 yards and 17 touchdowns. That earned him second-team All-America from The Associated Press and first-team All-SEC from both the league's coaches and the AP. The 17 scores still rank second on Florida's single-season list.

Doering wasn't a passenger, either. He helped the Gators win three straight SEC titles from 1993 to 1995. Jacksonville drafted him in the sixth round in 1996, and he lasted 10 seasons in the NFL with Indianapolis, Denver, Washington and Pittsburgh.

Ten years is a long time for a guy they once said was too slow and too small and not on scholarship.

THE PHONE CALL

The best part of this story isn't the stats. It's the phone call. Last summer, Florida SID Scott Burns called Doering. He said coach Jon Sumrall wanted to know whether Doering would be doing his show in Atlanta for SEC Championship weekend, and whether he'd speak to the team the Friday night before the game.

Doering admits his first thought was a raised eyebrow. "I'm thinking, 'Man, first year, they're already ambitious enough to believe they're going to be in the SEC Championship Game?'" he said. "I was like, 'Sure, I'll be happy to do it.' I figured we'd cross that bridge when we got there."

A few weeks later, with Florida in preseason camp, Burns called back. He wanted to "run something past" Doering, Tuesday at 2:35. The phone rang. Doering picked up and said, "What's up, Scott?"

It wasn't Scott. "Hey, this is actually Coach Sumrall. They talked football for a few minutes, the camp and what the staff was seeing. Then

Sumrall told him why he'd really called. "He goes, 'Well, sorry to mislead you, but we just wanted to break the news to you that you're going to be the legend representative for the Gators when we go to SEC Championship weekend,'" Doering said.

"I was almost in tears just hearing him say that. To have him take the time during training camp to deliver that news to me really made it even more special."

Give Sumrall credit. A first-year head coach in the middle of camp has a hundred things to do. He stopped to make that call himself, and that tells you he understands what Florida football is supposed to mean.

WHAT KEPT HIM GOING

As for the scout team, people don't know how punishing it is. Every walk-on has two or three days when you're ready to quit, beat up, ignored and wondering why you're doing it. Doering didn't quit. I asked him what kept him going.

"Couple things stand out to me, Buddy," he said. "One, we have this ignorance in life, some naivety, we'll call it. Luckily, we never know how hard the journey's going to be. Because if we knew in advance how hard it was going to be, we probably wouldn't sign up for it, you know?

“So I didn’t know what I was getting into. I believed in myself, and my parents supported me as a walk-on, paying for my school and housing and everything else. And so I just did it.

“And the luck that I had in playing for Coach Spurrier, who didn’t care if you were a walk-on or a scholarship player. He just wanted guys to compete and do the things they were coached to do. So I was just lucky with the timing of all of it.” Lucky? Maybe a little.

But luck doesn’t get you through a year of getting knocked flat by scholarship players while your parents pay the rent. Even after he made it, the road kept turning on him.

He became a hero at Kentucky, led the conference in catches a couple of weeks later, then landed in Spurrier’s doghouse and lost his playing time for the rest of the season. He had to earn his way back again.

“It’s never a direct path,” Doering said. “Success takes longer and is more of a convoluted path. But at the end, the sacrifice you make and the work you put in makes it that much more gratifying.”

Some people have asked him why this honor took so long. He doesn’t see it that way.

“There’s hundreds of players every single year on this team,” he said. “There’s way better players than I am that still haven’t been recognized. … So I’m just grateful to have the honor.”

That’s how a former walk-on thinks, even 30 years later.

THE LAST ONE

Now for the part that hurts. “We’re about to be in the last SEC Championship that we’ll ever have,” Doering said.

With playoff expansion coming, he believes this December’s game in Atlanta will be the final one. For those of us who watched it grow, that’s hard news.

Florida built that game. Spurrier, Wuerffel, Doering and a whole line of Gator All-Americans left their mark on it. The idea that it could disappear is devastating to all of them, and to me.

I reminded him of something Spurrier often says and Nick Saban said not long ago: for teams in the South, winning the SEC meant more than winning the national championship. That was certainly true in Florida.

Doering was there at the beginning. He played in the first four.

“At the inception of the SEC Championship Game in ‘92, when we went to Birmingham, we were like, ‘What is this?’” he said. “We had no idea what it was. It quickly became the original conference championship game. Nobody ever did it as good as the SEC did, especially when we moved to Atlanta and what it became. “It does mean more. I would say now you have a better chance of winning a national championship than you do an SEC championship, with only two teams making it. It’s a very huge honor to even play in that game.”

If he’s right about this year, the timing is almost too neat. A guy who was there at the start will be honored at the finish. The legend class will be celebrated Dec. 4 at the SEC Legends Celebration presented by T-Mobile at the College Football Hall of Fame in Atlanta. The honorees will be recognized again Dec. 5 before the SEC Championship Game at Mercedes-Benz Stadium. ‘Doering’s Got a Touchdown!’

No Gator fan will ever forget the night of Sept. 11, 1993, in Lexington. Florida’s quarterbacks threw seven interceptions that night. The

Gators trailed Kentucky 20-17 with seconds left. Then redshirt freshman Danny Wuerffel fired a 28-yard pass over the middle to the former walk-on, and Mick Hubert lost his mind on the radio:

“DOERING’S GOT A TOUCHDOWN! DOERING’S GOT A TOUCHDOWN! OHHHH MYYYY!”

Florida won 24-20 with three seconds to play. Doering has said that catch “changed the trajectory of my life.” It also helped launch a run of four straight SEC titles.

Plenty of players arrive at Florida with five stars and a scholarship. Chris Doering arrived with nothing but stubbornness.

They gave him a scout-team jersey and expected him to disappear, and in December he’s going to Atlanta as a legend. Doering’s got a touchdown! Again. Make that “The Legend’s Got A Touchdown!”

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

BUDDY MARTIN

GATOR FOOTBALL FEEL-GOOD: THE OPEN DATE IS SWEET MUSIC, BUT CHECK THE LYRICS

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 21, 2026

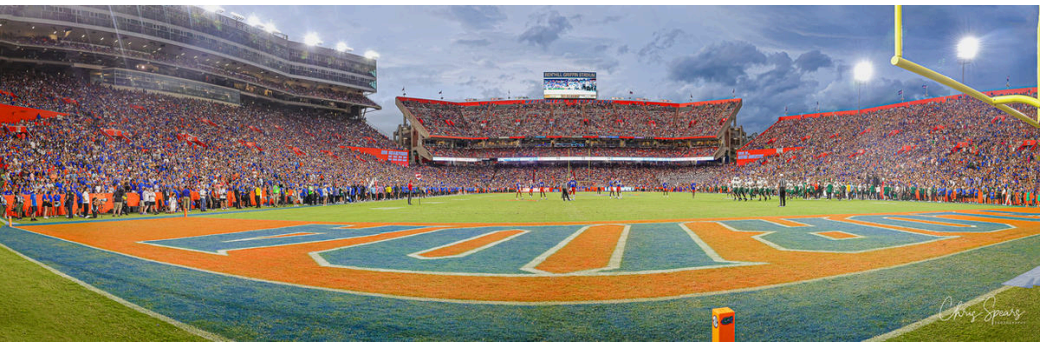


Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Two words on a football schedule don't mean much to most people: "Open Date." To a normal citizen it's a blank square on the calendar. It's a fine Saturday for a wedding, a trip to the mountains or finally cleaning the gutters.

But if your life is built around a football team, those two words sound like a Merle Haggard ballad drifting out of a jukebox. Sweet, a little sad and exactly what you needed to hear.

For Jon Sumrall, this week is that song.

His Gators have played seven straight Saturdays. They've been to the mountaintop, No. 8 in the country after running Ole Miss out

of the Swamp 52-28.

They've been in the ditch beside it, falling out of the poll after a homecoming loss to South Carolina. Then last weekend they went to Austin, where the barbecue smoke hangs over the interstate and nobody expects the visitors to leave happy, and beat No. 7 Texas 27-24.

That's a season's worth of mood swings in seven weeks. A team needs a nap.

So this Saturday in Gainesville, the practice fields will be quiet and the training room will be full. It'll be ice tubs instead of film sessions. Somewhere a backup linebacker will sleep until noon and call it the best thing to happen to him since signing day.

Florida is 5-2, ranked No. 20 and back in the conversation. That's the cheerful part.

Now for the part where I squint.

In their infinite wisdom, the voters put Texas at No. 19, one spot ahead of the Gators. That's the team Florida just beat on its own field. It's like losing the wrestling match and getting the trophy anyway because your singlet fit better.

I've been reading polls longer than some of those voters have been alive, and I still can't tell you what they're measuring.

Apparently neither can Mario Cristobal, but more on him in a minute.

THE HISTORY OF DOING NOTHING

Open dates get oversold, like a waterfront lot in Florida that comes with alligators.

Rest heals, but rest also rusts.

Look at 1996, the gold standard of Gator football. Steve Spurrier's national champions had three open dates that season: Sept. 14, Oct. 26 and Nov. 23.

Coming off the first, they went to Knoxville and beat No. 2 Tennessee 35-29. Coming off the second, they beat Georgia 47-7. Coming off the third, they went to Tallahassee and lost to Florida State 24-21 — due mostly to two regular offensive linemen being injured and out. And don't get me started on the late hits to "the echo of the whistle" by FSU.

So the most famous rest-week record in Gator history is 2-1, and the one blemish on a national champion came right after a week off.

Steve Spurrier got his revenge in the Sugar Bowl, 52-20, for the natty. As he put it, "we won the one that really counted the most." But that November, nobody in Gainesville was calling open dates magic.

The lesson then is the lesson now: the week off doesn't win anything. Depth does. A rested team with nobody behind the starters is just a team that's about to get tired again.

Florida has been on the other end of the calendar math, too. In 2019, the Gators and Miami opened in Week 0 in Orlando. That stretched a 12-game schedule over 15 weeks and gave Florida three open dates. Good teams use that kind of breathing room. Thin teams just get more time to worry.

MEANWHILE, DOWN IN CORAL GABLES

Here's where the record skips.

The same week Florida climbed back into the Top 25, guess who's sitting on top of it?

The Miami Hurricanes are No. 1 in the AP poll for the first time since Dec. 8, 2002. A whole generation of Canes fans had never seen it. Some only knew about it from uncles in gold chains.

They got there the hard way and the easy way at once. The hard way was a 43-35 double-overtime escape against Florida State. The easy way was No. 1 Georgia losing at home to unranked Auburn 27-24 while No. 2 Notre Dame lost at BYU.

Five of the top seven teams went down on one Saturday, a first in poll history.

Miami won the No. 1 ranking the way you win a hot-dog eating contest after everybody else gets sick.

To his credit, Cristobal isn't buying the crown. He called the ranking "absolutely insignificant and irrelevant with the changing of the guard from week to week." He's right. Texas held No. 1 and lost to unranked Oklahoma. Georgia took over and lost to unranked Auburn. In 2026, the top spot has been less a throne than a trap door.

Miami gets unranked Pitt this week. History says the Hurricanes should check the floorboards.

THE REAL REASON TO REST

Here's my footnote to the cheerful news. Florida's open date isn't exactly a head start, because Georgia is off this week, too. The two teams meet Oct. 31 in Atlanta. Not Jacksonville, which still feels like a priest saying Mass in a bowling alley. Both will arrive with fresh legs and fresh grudges.

The wise guys favor the Bulldogs by 12.5 points, with the over/under at 53.5. The same Bulldogs who lost to Auburn last week. Auburn, of

course, was one of the five teams the Gators had beaten this year, but put that aside for right now.

Georgia will be angry about Auburn, and Florida will be confident about Austin. The Bulldogs' staff will spend the week reminding the players how that loss felt. Sumrall will spend it hoping his players' ankles heal faster than their egos swell.

That's the job of an open date. It isn't for celebrating the last win; it's for getting ready for the next fight. Heal the ankles. Fix the pass protection. Remind the young guys that No. 20 is a number, not a résumé.

So enjoy the quiet Saturday, Gator Nation. Go to the wedding, take the trip, clean the gutters.

Just be back by Halloween. The music's about to get loud again.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

FRANZ BEARD

JONES VS. PHILO AND OTHER QB PERCEPTIONS, REALITIES

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 21, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

Nowhere in collegiate sports are the expectations higher than they are for quarterbacks tagged with a fifth star, most often by a recruiting analyst who might have been a star in the co-ed intramural flag football league back in the day. Five stars projects the perception of greatness even before the first collegiate snap is taken. It also projects the greatest perception of bust for those who don't measure up to expectations that range from stratospheric to walks on water.

Talent alone is no guarantor for success at quarterback, where borderline insane expectations have to deal with the reality of the greatest risk and overall the fewest rewards. Nationally since 2015 there have been 38 quarterbacks with a 5-star rating (per 247Sports) of which it could be said that seven performed up to or beyond expectations. The two 5-stars signed by the Florida Gators during that span – Feleipe Franks and DJ Lagway – had pockets of success before transferring out.

The quarterback under the most scrutiny at present and perhaps since some keyboard cowboy came up with star ratings is Arch Manning, described as a generational talent when he signed with Texas in 2023. After sitting two years while backing up Quinn Ewers, another 5-star whose career never matched expectations, Manning is 16-4 as the starter but very few of the winning starts have earned spectacular reviews. Three of the four losses are to unranked teams including a pair of blemishes at the hands of Florida.

It really isn't fair to compare Arch Manning with his Hall of Fame heritage – grandfather Archie and uncles Peyton and Eli – particularly in light of Texas coach Steve Sarkisian's track record with quarterback development. Quinn Ewers was also described as a generational talent but

his 27-9 record as the starting QB under Sarkisian left both the fan base and nation asking overhyped or undercoached? The same questions are being asked of Arch Manning, still the No. 1 QB at Texas even though Sarkisian is giving some first team reps to freshman KJ Lacey.

At Florida, where the quarterback position has produced three Heisman Trophy winners, eight have arrived since 2000 with 5-star ratings. Only two – Chris Leak and Tim Tebow – have proven worthy of the hype. Cam Newton also lived up to the hype but only after transferring to juco and then to Auburn. Those three have national championship rings to validate their 5-star ratings.

The most recent 5-star at Florida was DJ Lagway, who arrived in 2024 as the nation's No. 1 recruit. As a part-time starter in 2024 and full-time in 2025 he produced a 10-9 record and barely more touchdowns (28) than interceptions (23). Lagway is at Baylor now where his scattergun accuracy is creating calls for his benching in favor of Nate Bennett, a borderline 3-star when he arrived from a California high school in 2024.

There is no quarterback controversy at Florida currently where neither Aaron Philo nor Tramell Jones Jr. were anything close to 5-stars coming out of high school. Philo, a former 3-star recruit at Georgia Tech, started Florida's first six games (4-2 record) but an injury to the AC joint in his right (throwing) shoulder opened the door for Jones (former 4-star) to start last week against Texas, where he played turnover-free to beat the then 7th-ranked Longhorns and Manning in his first collegiate start. If Philo's injury lingers and Jones has continued success, it will force head coach Jon Sumrall to make a tough decision when Philo is healthy. Will he stick with the unwritten football rule that you don't lose your starting job to an injury or will he stick with the QB who is winning since taking over the job?

From a statistical and experience standpoint, Philo has the better track record but Jones, of course, hasn't had the opportunities. The one thing that Jones does have over Philo is a comeback win. Jones brought the Gators back from a 17-3 deficit to beat Texas in Austin and while his stats were quite average, they don't take into account inspiration. The troops responded to Jones. The two previous weeks against Missouri and South Carolina Philo was

unsuccessful in rallying the troops to mount a comeback. How will that factor into a starting QB decision when Philo is healthy to play again?

The only one who can answer that question is Sumrall who says he is confident the Gators can win with either Philo or Jones taking the snaps. There is no quarterback controversy at Florida now, but that's not to say it will hold true a couple of weeks from now.

FLORIDA QUARTERBACK SIGNEES SINCE 2000

SPURRIER RECRUITS

Brock Berlin (2000 5-star)

Ingle Martin (2001 4-star)

Notes: Berlin transferred to Miami 2001; Martin transferred to Furman 2004

ZOOK RECRUITS

Gavin Dickey (2002 4-star)

Patrick Dosh (2002 3-star)

Justin Midgett (2003 4-star)

Chris Leak (2003 5-star)

Notes: Dickey gave up football for baseball; Dosh transferred to ECU 2003; Midgett transferred to Eastern Illinois (2004)

MEYER RECRUITS

Josh Portis (2005 4-star)

Tim Tebow (2006 5-star)

Cameron Newton (2007 5-star)

John Brantley (2007 5-star)

Jordan Reed (2009 4-star)

Trey Burton (2010 4-star)

Tyler Murphy (2010 3-star)

Notes: Portis transferred to Maryland (2006); Tebow won the Heisman trophy at UF 2007; Newton transferred to Blinn JC then to Auburn where he won the 2010 Heisman; Brantley started 2010-11; Reed became an NFL tight end; Burton became an NFL tight end; Murphy transferred to Boston College 2014.

MUSCHAMP RECRUITS

Jeff Driskel (2011 5-star)

Jacoby Brissett (2011 4-star)

Skyler Mornhinweg (2012 3-star)

Max Staver (2013 3-star)

Will Grier (2014 4-star)

Treon Harris (2014 3-star)

Notes: Driskel started 2012-13 then transferred to Louisiana Tech 2014; Brissett transferred to North Carolina State 2013 and is still in the NFL; Mornhinweg transferred to Columbia 2015; Staver transferred to Tyler JC 2014 then to Houston Baptist and then to Maine; Grier transferred to West Virginia 2016; Harris transferred to Tennessee State 2017.

MCELWAIN RECRUITS

Feleipe Franks (2016 5-star)

Kyle Trask (2016 2-star)

Jake Allen (2017 3-star)

Notes: Franks started at UF 2017-18, injured game three 2019, transferred to Arkansas 2020, NFL tight end; Trask started last nine games 2019 and all of 2020, made Heisman podium in 2020; Allen transferred to Dartmouth 2018.

MULLEN RECRUITS

Emory Jones (2018 4-star)

Jalon Jones (2019 3-star)

Anthony Richardson (2020 4-star)

Carlos Del Rio-Wilson (2021 3-star)

Notes: Emory Jones started at UF 2021, transferred to Arizona State 2022 then to Cincinnati 2023; Jalon Jones dismissed from UF 2019, transferred to Jackson State; Richardson started at UF 2022 and was first round NFL Draft pick; Del Rio-Wilson transferred to Syracuse 2022; transferred to Marshall 2025 where he is the starting QB.

NAPIER RECRUITS

Max Brown (2022 3-star)

Jaden Rashada (2022 4-star/transferred to Arizona State)

Jack Miller (2022 transferred from Ohio State)

Graham Mertz (2023 transferred from Wisconsin)

DJ Lagway (2024 5-star)

Tramell Jones Jr. (2025 4-star)

Harrison Bailey (2024 transferred from Louisville)

Notes: Brown transferred to Charlotte 2024 then transferred to West Virginia 2025; Rashada signed with Florida, got out of his LOI, transferred to Arizona State 2023, transferred to Georgia 2024, transferred to Sacramento State 2025, transferred to Mississippi State

2026; Mertz started 2023 and had a season-ending ACL in 2024, drafted by Houston Texans NFL; Lagway started half of 2024, all of 2025, transferred to Baylor; Bailey transferred from Louisville and never played. Tramell Jones started at Texas and won last Saturday.

SUMRALL RECRUITS

Aaron Philo (transferred from Georgia Tech)

Will Griffin (2026 4-star)

Notes: Philo started first six games for Florida 2026; Griffin has yet to play.

STATS FOR FLORIDA'S 5-STAR QUARTERBACKS SINCE 2000

Brock Berlin (2000-01): 1-0 record as a starter; 53-87 for 653 yards (7.5 per attempt); 11 touchdowns, 2 interceptions.

Chris Leak (2003-06): 35-12 as a starter with the 2006 national championship; 895-1,458 for 11,213 yards (7.69 per attempt); 88 touchdowns, 42 interceptions.

Tim Tebow (2006-09): 35-6 as a starter; 2008 national championship; 2007 Heisman Trophy; 661-995 for 9,285 yards (9.33 per attempt); 88 touchdowns, 16 interceptions; 692-2,947 yards rushing for 57 touchdowns.

Cam Newton (2007-08): 0-0 as a starter; 6-12 for 53 yards (4.41 per attempt); 21-113 rushing for four touchdowns.

John Brantley IV (2007-11): 15-9 as a starter; 398-645 for 4,750 yards (7.36 per attempt); 30 touchdowns, 18 interceptions.

Jeff Driskel (2011-14): 14-6 as a starter; 328-552 for 3,411 yards (6.17 per attempt); 23 touchdowns, 20 interceptions; 220-649 yards rushing for nine touchdowns.

Feleipe Franks (2017-19): 16-8 as a starter; 367-622 for 4,593 yards (7.38 per attempt); 38 touchdowns, 17 interceptions; 189-438 for eight rushing touchdowns.

DJ Lagway (2024-25): 10-9 as a starter; 328-529 for 4,179 yards (7.89 per attempt); 28 touchdowns, 23 interceptions; 121-237 for one rushing touchdown.

NATIONAL FIVE STAR QUARTERBACKS SINCE 2015

2015

1. Jarrett Stidham, Baylor

2. Josh Rosen UCLA

3. Blake Barnett, Alabama

4. Kyler Murray, Texas A&M

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

13. Sam Darnold, USC

15. Joe Burrow, Ohio State

18. Lamar Jackson, Louisville

2016

1. Shea Patterson, Ole Miss

2. Jacob Eason, Georgia

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

5. Dwayne Haskins, Ohio State

6. Feleipe Franks, Florida

10. Jalen Hurts, Alabama

39. Justin Herbert Oregon

2017

1. Davis Mills, Stanford

2. Tua Tagovailoa, Alabama

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

3. Jake Fromm, Georgia

11. James Blackman, Florida State

12. Hendon Hooker, Tennessee

19. Kenny Pickett, Pittsburgh

29. Mac Jones, Alabama

39. Jake Allen, Florida

2018

1. Trevor Lawrence, Clemson

2. Justin Fields, Georgia

3. JT Daniels, Southern Cal

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

8. Matt Corral, Ole Miss

10. Tyler Shough, Oregon

16. Emory Jones, Florida

49. Will Levis, Penn State

50. Brock Purdy, Iowa State

2019

1. Spencer Rattler, Oklahoma

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

2. Jayden Daniels, Arizona State

3. Bo Nix, Auburn

7. Graham Mertz, Wisconsin

22. Jalon Jones, Florida

2020

1. Bryce Young, Alabama

2. DJ Uiagalelei, Clemson

3. CJ Stroud, Ohio State

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

8. Harrison Bailey, Tennessee

10. Haynes King, Texas A&M

13. Carson Beck, Georgia

14. Anthony Richardson, Florida

27. Jack Miller, Ohio State

33. Max Johnson, LSU

39. TJ Finley, LSU

52. Brady Cook, Missouri

53. Will Rogers, Mississippi State

2021

1. Quinn Ewers, Ohio State

2. Caleb Williams, Oklahoma

3. Sam Huard, Washington

4. Drake Maye, North Carolina

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

13. Jaxson Dart, Southern Cal

14. Jalen Milroe, Alabama

19. Garrett Nussmeier, LSU

31. Carlos Del Rio-Wilson, Florida

37. Shedeur Sanders, Jackson State

2022

1. Drew Allar, Penn State

2. Cade Klubnik, Clemson

3. Conner Weigman, Texas A&M

4. Ty Simpson, Alabama

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

7. Gunner Stockton, Georgia

35. Max Brown, Florida

40. Noah Fifita, Arizona

42. Josh Hoover, TCU

57. Ashton Daniels, Stanford

61. Rocco Becht, Iowa State

75. Byrum Brown, South Florida

2023

1. Arch Manning, Texas

2. Nico Iamaleava, Tennessee

3. Dante Moore, UCLA

4. Jackson Arnold, Oklahoma

5. Malachi Nelson, Southern Cal

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

6. Jaden Rashada, Florida/Arizona State

8. Austin Mack, Washington

9. Avery Johnson Kansas State

14. Kenny Minchey, Notre Dame

18. Sam Leavitt, Michigan State

20. Marcel Reed, Texas A&M

34. LaNorris Sellers, South Carolina

35. Austin Simmons, Ole Miss

2024

1. DJ Lagway, Florida

2. Dylan Raiola, Nebraska

3. Julian Sayin, Ohio State

Other notables not 5-star with national ranking:

4. Luke Kromhoek, Florida State

6. CJ Carr, Notre Dame

10. Ryan Puglisi, Georgia

19. Demond Williams Jr., Arizona

47. Aaron Philo, Georgia Tech

57. Whit Muschamp, Vanderbilt

2025

1. Bryce Underwood, Michigan

2. Keelon Russell, Alabama

3. Tavien St. Clair, Ohio State

4. Husan Longstreet, Stanford

Other notables with national ranking:

8. Kamario Taylor, Mississippi State

17. George MacIntyre, Tennessee

25. Tramell Jones Jr., Florida

34. Bear Bachmeier, Stanford

2026

1. Keisean Henderson, Houston

2. Jared Curtis, Vanderbilt

3. Faizon Brandon, Tennessee

Other notables with national ranking:

5. Dia Bell, Texas

16. Will Griffin, Florida

21. Dereon Coleman, Miami

Photo courtesy UAA (University Athletic Association, FloridaGators.com) and Hannah White. See more of her work on Instagram, and the official Florida Gators photo galleries at FloridaGators.com.

Read it on gatorbaitmedia.com

SATURDAY IN THE SEC

Five SEC games on Halloween. Kickoffs and TV: ESPN scoreboard. All times ET. The Soothsayer's picks post Friday on gatorbaitmedia.com.

12:45 P.M. SEC NETWORK

Auburn (4-3) at No. 12 Ole Miss (5-2)

MISS -13.5 · O/U 57.5

3:30 P.M. ABC

No. 17 Florida (5-2) vs. No. 3 Georgia (6-1)

(Neutral site, Atlanta)

UGA -11.5 · O/U 55.5

4:15 P.M. SEC NETWORK

South Carolina (4-3) at Oklahoma (4-3)

OU -5.5 · O/U 44.5

7:30 P.M. ESPN

Mississippi State (4-3) at No. 11 Texas (5-2)

TEX -21 · O/U 50.5

7:45 P.M. SEC NETWORK

No. 23 Missouri (5-2) at Arkansas (3-4)

MIZ -10 · O/U 49.5

Kickoffs, TV, records, rankings and DraftKings lines: ESPN SEC scoreboard for Oct. 31 and the AP Top 25 (Week 9), read Oct. 27. Alabama, Kentucky, LSU, Tennessee, Texas A&M and Vanderbilt are idle.

HOW TO WATCH

KICKOFF

Saturday, Oct. 31, 3:30 p.m. ET

TV

ABC (Chris Fowler, Kirk Herbstreit, Holly Rowe)

STREAM

ESPN app (ESPN on ABC), with a TV-provider login

RADIO

Gator Sports Network, pregame from 12:15 p.m. ET; SiriusXM 145 and the SiriusXM app; ESPN Gainesville WRUF and The Varsity Network

PREGAME TV

SEC Nation from Atlanta on Saturday morning

WHERE

Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta. Neutral site

Monday's Buddy Martin Show: Sumrall won't name a QB for Georgia

The live-show post, with the watch link

Sources: FloridaGators.com broadcast information (Oct. 27) and SEC Nation announcement (Oct. 24); ESPN game summary

REFERENCE DESK

Roster

Schedule and results

Georgia week guide

The Buddy Martin Show

Next up: Oklahoma in Gainesville, Saturday, Nov. 7, 7:45 p.m. ET, SEC Network.

BEST SHOTS

From Florida 27, No. 7 Texas 24, the last time out · Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com)



Sumrall in the locker room. Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com).



Kanye Clark with the game-sealing fumble. Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com).



Tramell Jones Jr. on the move. Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com).



The defense swarms. Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com).



The locker room after Austin. Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com).

The game story on gatorbaitmedia.com

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Florida Gators galleries at floridagators.com/galleries. Illustrations by GatorBait Media.

Statistics, rankings and betting lines: ESPN, with the DraftKings line via ESPN. Series history, broadcast information and availability reports: FloridaGators.com.

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Next up: Oklahoma in Gainesville, Saturday, Nov. 7, 7:45 p.m. ET, SEC Network.

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